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Richard Knightley (d. 1639) and Puritan socio-political and commercial activity
during the Personal Rule of Charles I.

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Introduction

This dissertation examines the life of Richard Knightley (d. 1639), and seeks to understand his place within the community of the godly during the Personal Rule of Charles I. Knightley, a scion of a notable Northamptonshire gentry family and an MP in some of the parliaments of the 1620s who returned to his Northamptonshire homes in Fawsley and Preston Capes during the Personal Rule, is an obscure figure who occupies a marginal place in histories of early Stuart Puritanism. Despite his deep connections across multiple branches of the Puritan community across early Stuart England and within his own county, Knightley has received little specific scholarly attention. Nonetheless, he has acquired a generalised label: that of the radical Puritan. His political connections were apparently substantive enough that Richard Cust suggests in Knightley's entry in the *Oxford Dictionary of National Biography* that Knightley, 'had he survived [past 1639]... would surely have been an influential member of the parliamentary leadership during the civil war'.¹

A substantial part of this dissertation is concerned with investigating Cust's claim. Although the relative paucity of surviving political writing by Knightley means that no first-hand statement of his beliefs exists, this does not preclude one from attempting to understand them by reconstructing his social, intellectual, and religious world. To this end, this dissertation adopts a broadly prosopographical approach, examining Knightley's relationships with other Puritan men who moved in the same social circles, shared the patronage of certain priests, and were members of the same set of colonial companies. This somewhat resembles the most traditional historiographical approaches to the proto-parliamentary grouping during the Personal Rule. In *History of the Rebellion*, the Earl of Clarendon described the parliamentary group during the Personal Rule as 'a kind of fraternity of many persons of good condition, who chose to live together in one family at a gentleman's house of a fair fortune... [maintaining] a joint and mutual correspondence and conversation together with much familiarity and friendship...'.² Knightley's placement within local and national groups of Puritans forms the focus of this investigation. Such an approach has precedent in more recent histories: Peter Lake and Isaac Stephens used testimony from a wide number of connected individuals to piece together the beliefs of the Northamptonshire godly minister John Barker, executed alongside two women on a religiously charged accusation of infanticide in 1637.³ One can catch a glimpse of the relationships Knightley enjoyed with like-minded godly men by examining the diaries of those who moved in similar circles. One example is the diary of Thomas Dugard, a minor Warwickshire cleric supported by Knightley's associate Lord Brooke, whose accounts of encounters with Knightley illustrate the range and diversity of men in his orbit, many of whom harboured serious dissatisfaction with Charles's policies.⁴ Likewise, the diary of Northamptonshire Puritan Robert

¹Richard Cust, 'Knightley, Richard (1593–1639)', *Oxford Dictionary of National Biography* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2009).

²Edward Hyde, Earl of Clarendon, *The History of the Rebellion and Civil Wars in England*, ed. W. D. Macray, 6 vols. (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1888), IV, 242–43.

³Peter Lake and Isaac Stephens, *Scandal and Religious Identity in Early Stuart England: A Northamptonshire Maid's Tragedy* (Woodbridge: The Boydell Press, 2015).

⁴Ann Hughes, 'Thomas Dugard and his Circle in the 1630s — A 'Parliamentary-Puritan' Connexion?', *Historical Journal* 29, no. 4 (1986), 771–93.

Woodford offers an insight into the godly life of Knightley's county.

Nicholas Tyacke has taken aim at the tendency of historians of the early Stuart period towards biography, describing the genre of writing as an 'unsatisfactory' one that leads to over-emphasising individual peculiarities at the expense of broader themes. He instead expresses a preference for approaches that draw upon 'a cast of many characters'.⁵ This study of Knightley, furnished largely with second-hand evidence from those who associated with him and featuring a number of close studies of his associates, sits somewhere between a biographical approach and the 'cast of characters' approach. This runs the risk of descending into typecasting, where a briefly mentioned character, afforded a label like 'conformist' or 'non-conformist', might be used to signal Knightley's beliefs through association before being thrown away. Tyacke has warned against this tendency, and this dissertation takes efforts to avoid it.

Lake suggested that the imposition of Laudianism was a radicalising experience for early Stuart Puritans, uniting and politicising previously inert networks of piety within and between counties.⁶ This contrasts markedly with the state of Puritanism within the Elizabethan church, which he characterised as a largely non-radical movement for reform grounded within the Anglican communion.⁷ Knightley lived in a period of flux for many Puritans. There is adequate evidence to suggest that Knightley, who refused to implement Laudian altar policy at his family chapel in Fawsley and provided shelter to some of Laudianism's most stringent critics, was an opponent of Laudian reform.⁸ Although this helps to establish Knightley's broad position it is not sufficient to pinpoint his politics, as Puritanism was not a coherent political movement throughout the period. Although Knightley was deeply anti-papist and supported some of the same non-conformist preachers who ministered to his grandfather, Sir Richard Knightley, there are many ways in which he does not adhere to the typical image of a non-conformist Puritan. For example, Knightley was a close associate of the Duke of Buckingham in the early 1620s. Despite some suggestions from historians to the contrary, his removal from Westminster in the middle of the 1620s does not appear to have been an official response to radicalism. Moreover, his membership of Puritan colonial companies in the period, although held up by some as proof of his political identity, was not necessarily a marker of political opposition.

In her 2022 DPhil thesis, Christy Wang suggested that the prevalence of the 'Puritan/Laudian antithesis' as an analytical device in existing historiography of the early Stuart godly community in Northamptonshire had the effect of ironing out much of the nuance of conformity and non-conformity. She posited that, although Tom Webster's analysis of the reaction of Northamptonshire Puritan social networks to Laudian reform is of substantial value to historians, it failed to appreciate the subtleties that defined the lives of 'comfortable' or otherwise not outwardly radical Puritans.⁹

⁵Nicholas Tyacke, *Aspects of English Protestantism, c. 1530–1700* (Manchester: Manchester University Press, 2001), 20.

⁶Peter Lake, *On Laudianism: Piety, Polemic and Politics During the Personal Rule of Charles I* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2023), 261.

⁷Peter Lake, *Moderate Puritans and the Elizabethan Church* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1982).

⁸John Fielding, 'Conformists, Puritans and the Church Courts: The Diocese of Peterborough, 1603–42' (unpublished PhD thesis, University of Birmingham, 1989), 146–61.

⁹Christy Wang, 'Puritan Conformity, Church Polity, and Anglican Identity, 1628–88' (unpublished DPhil thesis,

Wang criticised Webster for having misinterpreted the actions of conformist Puritans of the late 1630s, in particular Edward Reynolds, as examples of individuals giving concessions to Laudianism, or even converting to Laudianism themselves.¹⁰ This dissertation will criticise a similar, if inverted, historiographical tendency in the discussion of Knightley, whose religious and political identity has been flattened out to simply that of a radically reformed Puritan. The religious world of the Personal Rule was an uncertain one, within which boundaries were liable to shift. Noah Millstone's recent work on the religious life of the bishop of Lincoln, John Williams, has explored with some skill how some individuals could, by toeing the line between different religious sects, play a 'double game' and exploit the religious tensions of early Stuart England for their own political or social ends.¹¹ Knightley does not seem to have been one of these characters, but he does appear to have maintained connections on both the radical and conformist sides of early Stuart Puritanism.

Ultimately, no historian can confidently assert what Knightley's politics were because he never had the chance to express them. For most members of the Puritan gentry, it would not be until after the first meeting of the Short Parliament and the arrival of the Root and Branch petition that the political correlative effects of their religion came into clear focus. It was then that it became necessary for the godly to make an active choice in national politics, the polarisation between moderate and radical Puritans became clear, and the relative religious positions of different actors became clear. Cust's suggestion about Knightley is therefore only speculation. To borrow an image from Antonio Gramsci's writing, surveying Knightley's life is like being at the cinema when the film rips without warning and the picture is cut short before the third act in a moment of dazzling light, and one stumbles blinking outside, none the wiser about how it ends.¹²

University of Oxford, 2022), 10.

¹⁰Tom Webster, *Godly Clergy in Early Stuart England: The Caroline Puritan Movement, c. 1620–1643* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1997), 215–34.

¹¹Noah Millstone, 'Bishop Williams among the Puritans, 1621–1640', *English Historical Review* 140, no. 606 (2025), 976–1014.

¹²Antonio Gramsci, *Sotto la Mole 1916–1920*, (Turin: Giulio Einaudi, 1960), 11.

Chapter 1: Politics and Officeholding

This chapter will situate Richard Knightley within the national political context of Caroline England, and examines how he related national political developments to his position as a local officeholder in Northamptonshire. In particular, it will focus on how Knightley's experience as a local JP illustrates how officeholding became an arena in which national religio-political tensions could be expressed in the localities during the Personal Rule. Drawing comparisons within the highly diverse political world of the early Stuarts is challenging, but Knightley's experience of the period appears to have resembled that of others. He was a member of the broad Puritan religio-political *milieu* who, like several other disillusioned Puritans recruited into the Duke of Buckingham's orbit in the earlier part of the period, underwent a political conversion in the 1620s, appearing to adopt a much more hostile, although never openly oppositional, stance towards the government. As a county man in his final years, he appears to have reconciled his antagonistic view of the government's policy with a sense of his duty as an officeholder, much as more notable men like Richard Grosvenor did.

Forthcoming chapters will discuss the matrix of religious and commercial connections that tied Knightley to other prominent Puritan figures. Most of these strands of Knightley's political engagement were not wholly separate from his county connections, but in the interest of coherence, they will be considered separately. One of the most important social connections Knightley apparently maintained during the Personal Rule was with a man who, although not a county man, represented an exceptional national transplant into the local politics of Northamptonshire: John Pym, who, according to J. H. Hexter's famous account, had 'displaced the king as the active centre of the state' by 1642.¹³

Given the focus on Knightley's county role, it is first necessary to consider the wider historiographical context of seventeenth-century county politics. The rise and fall of the county study was tied to the fortunes of 'localism' as a key interpretative concept in the writing of early Stuart political history. The notion of the 'county community' was first fully articulated by Alan Everitt in the 1960s and, together with the broader concept of 'localism', would become a central conceptual tool for John Morrill, Conrad Russell, and other early revisionists. By the middle of the 1970s, the turn towards localism had become so significant that Robert Ashton would hail the 'emphasis on local and regional studies' as 'the most important single development in the historiography of the Civil War in the last quarter of a century', identifying Morrill's *Revolt of the Provinces* as the culmination of this intellectual tradition.¹⁴ Many county studies have emphasised that localism among the gentry came at the expense of national politico-religious action. The gentry of Kent, as described by Everitt in his survey of that county at the outset of the Civil War, formed an almost wholly self-contained community that drew its estates, brides, and friends from the county and rarely left it. In a sense, the majority of their lives were centred on their county community.¹⁵ This appears

¹³J. H. Hexter, *The Reign of King Pym* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1941), 5.

¹⁴Robert Ashton, *The English Civil War: Conservatism and Revolution, 1603–1649* (London: Weidenfeld and Nicolson, 1978); John Morrill, *Revolt in the Provinces: The People of England and the Tragedies of War, 1630–1648*, 2nd edn (London: Longman, 1999).

¹⁵Alan Everitt, *The Community of Kent and the Great Rebellion, 1640–60* (Leicester: Leicester University Press,

to have been a widespread experience of county life, with Richard Cust expounding upon this view by suggesting that the English polity in the first half of the seventeenth century can be seen as an ‘association of semi-autonomous county communities... essentially adversarial [to the centre]’.¹⁶ According to this view, the majority of the gentry were largely ambivalent about the religio-political conflicts among the national political elite, and were chiefly concerned with protecting the interests of their counties from the demands and influence of the centre.

The notion of the entirely insular county community came under rightful challenge from the early 1980s onward. The charge was initially led by Clive Holmes in his seminal essay ‘The County Community in Stuart Historiography’ and was followed up at greater length by a series of what can be termed ‘post-revisionist’ county studies. This corpus of work indicates how diverse the local experience of politics was in this period, and how regularly some county communities engaged with the national religio-political scene in complex ways. Such engagements arose in response to financial exactions, religious divisions, or beliefs about the relationship between parliament and local factions. Many of these histories demonstrate the extent to which the political character of a county was in part a function of the sort of people and officials who were the focus of attention there at any given time. Just as the leadership of Sir Richard Grosvenor brought about a materially different political climate in Cheshire to that produced under the political leadership of William Davenport, so too could the inclinations of prominent local officeholders, whether Puritan, Laudian, or somewhere in between, go a long way towards determining the politico-religious culture of other counties. Two such county studies are particularly relevant to this dissertation and cover the geographical area in which Knightley operated. The first is Ann Hughes’s study of the relatively more ‘open’ county of Warwickshire, in whose Puritan *milieu* Knightley moved.¹⁷ Hughes argues that the politics of early Stuart social relations in Warwickshire, were ‘inextricably bound up with Westminster politics’.¹⁸ The second is an unpublished PhD thesis by John Fielding, who conducted a survey of the religio-political scene in Northamptonshire during the first half of the seventeenth century. Both works assert that there was no sharp division between the ‘local’ and ‘national’ spheres in the political culture of these counties during Knightley’s lifetime.

Taking this approach, one can see how the political partisanship which precipitated the violence of the English Civil War was, in Ronald Hutton’s unusually visceral turn of phrase, ‘artificially inseminated’ into counties through an elite network of politically aligned individuals.¹⁹ By studying the interaction between Knightley’s national political standing and his local engagement, one can more closely examine this process of political ‘insemination’ in Northamptonshire, while also contributing to a more general understanding of the development of political loyalties within counties

1966), 13–14.

¹⁶Richard Cust and Peter Lake, *Gentry Culture and the Politics of Religion: Cheshire on the Eve of Civil War* (Manchester: Manchester University Press, 2020), 2.

¹⁷Clive Holmes, ‘The County Community in Stuart Historiography’, *Journal of British Studies* 19, no. 2 (1980), 54–73; Ann Hughes, *Politics, Society and Civil War in Warwickshire, 1620–1660* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1987).

¹⁸Hughes, *Politics, Society and Civil War in Warwickshire*, 231.

¹⁹Ronald Hutton, *The Royalist War Effort, 1642–1646* (London: Longman, 1982).

during the Personal Rule. Peter Lake has suggested that the absence of a parliament significantly affected how opponents of government measures could frame their reactions: opposition expressed through the king's council, before the High Commission, or at court was suppressed by circumstance.²⁰ Critics of the government became more reliant on informal 'networks' to coordinate their activities. Knightley's position within the social *milieu* of Parliament men during the 1620s and 1630s - the two decades of public life he enjoyed between the age of twenty-six and his death at forty-six - is therefore a particularly fertile subject for study.

Although this dissertation will principally focus on Knightley's extra-parliamentary activities during the Personal Rule, Knightley's fairly irregular, although usually high-tempered, interventions as an MP in the parliaments of the 1620s (almost exclusively on religious matters) are useful for sketching out the shape of his beliefs. Upon the failure of the Spanish match in February 1624, Knightley warned the house that he 'hath heard active papists speak of their number, and therefore his fear is greater than any man's else, and he would have a care taken as well of the papists in the country as those here about London'. He suggested to parliament, as he also suggested in surviving private correspondence, that a national programme of surveillance should be undertaken against papists, with all knights responsible for ascertaining and recording the exact numbers of Catholics in their respective shires.²¹ In 1625, he attacked the government's failure to adequately enforce recusancy laws, echoing fairly standard Puritan conspiratorial grumblings around the Spanish match.²² He similarly expressed his adamant opposition to the instruction of priests in Arminianism.²³ On constitutional matters, Knightley was more quiet. As will be explored in later chapters, his parliamentary connections pursued a diverse range of political objectives in the parliaments of the 1620s.

Surprisingly for a Puritan of his standing, Knightley began his career in parliament by positioning himself closely to James I's favourite, the Duke of Buckingham. This relationship was likely initiated by Buckingham, who had been attempting to recruit Puritan support for an anti-Catholic war against Spain to recover his fallen star in the wake of the failed Spanish match. Knightley appears to have been successfully wooed and, as Conrad Russell suggests, 'combined his Puritanism with being a Buckingham client', tempering his political radicalism for the initial part of the 1620s.²⁴ Buckingham recruited a number of Puritans to his cause, including many who had been responsible for significant opposition to James in the previous parliament like Sir Dudley Digges, Sir Robert Phelps, and Sir Edwin Sandys. This indicates that Knightley was considered an influential enough member of the Puritan gentry to cultivate as an ally.

Knightley appears to have enjoyed being one of Buckingham's pocket Puritans. His correspon-

²⁰Peter Lake, 'The Collection of Ship Money in Cheshire during the Sixteen-Thirties: A Case Study of Relations between Central and Local Government', *Northern History* 17, no. 1 (1981), 44-71.

²¹Robert E. Ruigh, *The Parliament of 1624: Politics and Foreign Policy* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1971), 169.

²²Maija Jansson and William B. Bidwell (eds.), *Proceedings in Parliament 1625* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1987), 249.

²³Conrad Russell, *Parliaments and English Politics, 1621-1629* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1979), 345.

²⁴*Ibid.*, 152.

dence with Buckingham in 1624, in which he addresses the duke as the ‘illustrious’ George Villiers and lobbies him for an even more hostile approach towards Spain, is rather unctuous.²⁵ Knightley’s closeness to the royal favourite was likely inherited from his close acquaintance Edward Montagu, whom he succeeded as an MP in 1621. Montagu was a moderate, whom James I accused of having ‘smelt a little of Puritanism’ in the 1620s, but would eventually join the Civil War on the royalist side.²⁶ Perhaps Knightley was similarly happy to combine his reformed religion with loyalty to the court. As part of his effort to ally Puritans to his cause, Buckingham became close to Knightley’s principal priest, John Preston, who will be encountered in later chapters. Buckingham played a central role in Preston becoming a chaplain-in-ordinary to Prince Charles in 1620, an appointment made on the advice of Sir Ralph Freeman, a relative of Preston, who had recommended action to placate the Puritan minority. Buckingham assisted Preston again in September 1622, writing to the then-master of Emmanuel College, Laurence Chaderton, to insist that it was the wish of the king and the prince that he should resign in favour of Preston, and promising him a ‘supply of maintenance’ if he did.

It forms a significant milestone in Knightley’s political development that, along with Preston and his friend Sir John Eliot, he entirely reversed his position on Buckingham in the middle of the 1620s.²⁷ As noted, he was one of Buckingham’s men in the parliament of 1624. However, by the time he returned to parliament in 1628, he had changed his opinion to such an extent that he stridently asserted in the House that he counted the royal favourite as ‘an enemy, not to this state only, but to all Christendom’.²⁸ This statement, made before Buckingham’s murder and in the aftermath of the 1626 dissolution of parliament, when it had become clear that Charles was determined to stand by the duke no matter what, appears to amount to a rather forthright political declaration. However, instead of resulting from a profound political shift, Knightley’s reversal appears to have stemmed from a misunderstanding.

Before the outset of the Personal Rule, Knightley defended the government’s policy against recusancy with some eagerness while exercising his duties as a deputy lieutenant in Northamptonshire. In 1625, he ‘took a blow on the face’ from Lord Vaux while determinedly attempting to enter and search Vaux’s Northamptonshire home, in pursuit of his orders from the government to inspect recusants’ homes for arms.²⁹ In the ensuing fight, Knightley accused Vaux of using a ‘cudgel taken from some standerby’ to beat one of Knightley’s servants, one Mr Hambleton, until ‘blood [was] running about his ears’.³⁰ In response to Vaux’s violence, Knightley complained to the council and almost immediately announced his intention to pursue action against him in the Star Chamber.³¹

²⁵ *Fortescue Papers*, ed. S. R. Gardiner, Camden Series (London: Camden Society, 1871), 196–97.

²⁶ S. M. Thorpe, ‘Montagu, Edward II (1562–1644), of Boughton, Northants.’, *History of Parliament: The House of Commons 1558–1603* (Woodbridge: Boydell and Brewer, 1981).

²⁷ Conrad Russell, ‘Eliot, Sir John (1592–1632)’, *Oxford Dictionary of National Biography* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2004).

²⁸ Robert C. Johnson et al. (eds.), *Commons Debates 1628*, 6 vols. (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1977–83), IV, 120.

²⁹ *Calendar of State Papers Domestic, 1625–26* (London: HMSO, 1858), 142.

³⁰ Godfrey Anstruther, *Vaux of Harrowden: A Recusant Family*, 2nd edn (Newport, Mon.: R. H. Johns, 1953), 443.

³¹ Thomas Birch and Robert Folkestone Williams, *The Court and Times of Charles the First*, 2 vols. (London:

In this case, Knightley's energetic exercise of his duties probably derived just as much from his hatred of recusancy as from any particular devotion to service.

Alongside a number of other MPs who had been members of the Oxford parliament, Knightley was pricked as sheriff in the winter of 1625. It is a matter of historical agreement that, in making this series of appointments, Charles was using this royal prerogative as a device to sideline difficult MPs without having to go to the trouble of arresting them. Among this number were Sir Edward Coke and Sir Thomas Wentworth.³² This strategy was effective because a sheriff was obliged to remain within the limits of his shrievalty unless he had royal permission to depart. Although many of these MPs were selected on the basis of their previous hostility to Buckingham and the government, Knightley, who was not openly hostile before this incident, does not fit the mould. Notably, Knightley was also not recommended by the judges for appointment in advance and appears to have been appointed sheriff unexpectedly at his hearing. In what might have been an enormous stroke of bad luck for Knightley, the day of his hearing was the day that the sheriffs were pricked.³³ This suggests that, rather than falling victim to a premeditated scheme to exclude opposition, Knightley appears to have been the unlucky subject of a spur-of-the-moment decision by Charles, eager to use his newfound power to punish Knightley for his tactless handling of a close ally.

Evidence from state papers about Vaux's Star Chamber case, which concluded in the presence of the king on 13 November, supports this thesis. Joseph Mead records that the king, having heard the details of the case and Vaux's sentence (being imprisoned in Fleet), responded: 'Now he shall have work enough. . . Mr Knightley is to be sheriff'.³⁴ Instead of indicating that Knightley had undergone a political transformation, it appears that this appointment was an almost random exercise of the king's power. This unexpected announcement was a source of both chagrin and amazement to Knightley. In his correspondence with Buckingham, Lord Conway describes Knightley as entirely 'perplexed' by his appointment, defending himself against accusations of disloyalty by reference to 'his speeches and the endeavours he had used in the parliament for the service of the king and honour of [Buckingham]'. With this plea having failed, Knightley appears to have concluded that Buckingham and the rest of the king's advisers were responsible, and he shifted to 'protest[ing] the continual and sole dependence' of the king upon them, despite the king having personally presided over Knightley's humiliating hearing.³⁵ Mead hints that the king was attempting to protect his associate Vaux, who was linked to the failure of the Spanish match through his association with the Infanta. Viscount Mandeville, in something of an understatement, concluded that 'Dick Knightley be discontent with his sheriffwick'.³⁶ The king added to his duties in the county by appointing him a commissioner for the Forced Loan in Northamptonshire in the following year.³⁷

Henry Colburn, 1848), I, 56.

³²Andrew Thrush and John P. Ferris (eds.), *The History of Parliament: The House of Commons 1604–1629* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press for the History of Parliament Trust, 2010), I, 1.

³³Anstruther, *Vaux of Harrowden*, 448.

³⁴*Ibid.*

³⁵British Library, Harley MS 1580, fol. 342, correspondence between Conway and Buckingham.

³⁶Historical Manuscripts Commission, *Report on the Manuscripts of the Duke of Buccleuch and Queensberry, Preserved at Montagu House, Whitehall* (London: HMSO, 1899–1926), I, 262.

³⁷Thomas Rymer, *Foedera* (London: J. Tonson, 1704–35), VIII, pt. 2, 145.

With Vaux having secured a full pardon and a release from the Fleet by the end of the same month, Knightley had been bested by a papist. His correspondence with Montagu at the end of 1625 reaches a fever-pitch of anti-popery and open hostility to the king's councillors, as he continued to rail against the king's advisors and complain about the influence of the 'papists we have in the county' and the need for them to be under much greater surveillance, 'so the King may (as in a glass) see the danger he was in'. Montagu, one of the most conformist of the Puritans in the period, refused to act on Knightley's advice on the basis that he ought not to act in advance of any official guidance.³⁸ Having failed to win back the support of those close to the king, and now saddled with the shrievalty, Knightley used its strictures to his advantage wherever he could. In 1630, 'Precise Ric Knightley' was recorded by the Earl of Exeter as among those refusing to pay knighthood fines, with Knightley claiming that his appointment as a sheriff, which had prevented him from leaving Northamptonshire at the time of the coronation, was the reason he was unable to pay.³⁹ By the end of the 1620s, Knightley's position appears to have been one of subdued opposition to the government.

Although Knightley's *tournant* away from the Caroline regime was particularly historically contingent, it does follow a fairly typical pattern overall. Richard Cust has identified many other politicians whom Buckingham had cultivated, but who by the end of the 1620s openly expressed discomfort at the government's hostility to parliament.⁴⁰ It would be fair to trace Knightley's political development alongside one of them, John Eliot. Knightley had come to know Eliot through an indirect university connection - his cousin Thomas tutored Eliot's sons at Lincoln College, Oxford.⁴¹ Although Knightley's letters to Eliot have not survived, Eliot's missives to Knightley, written while held in the Tower of London, suggest that Knightley was sympathetic to Eliot's plight. Eliot thanks Knightley for his 'love' and support, and suggests that he visit him in the Tower, although 'there is soe little to invite [Knightley] to'.⁴² Knightley's changing allegiances in the parliaments of the latter part of the 1620s appear to have matched Eliot's, suggesting that the two might have had similar politics. Russell notes that by 1628, Knightley had joined the ranks of Pym and the Earl of Warwick in 'weaving... a coherent fabric of terror' for the government.⁴³ Cust identifies the Forced Loan as one of the principal agitating factors that pushed men, of whom Knightley would presumably be one, away from the government camp. Although other factors contributed to Knightley's emerging hostility to the regime, he was agitated by the levy in a way that Montagu, who described the payment as a part of the 'duty of one Christian Brother... to another', was not.⁴⁴ In January 1627, he attended a meeting in Northampton where a petition of local freeholders and gentry was agreed, which he supported, demanding that the levy be approved by parliament before they paid

³⁸HMC, *Buccleuch and Queensberry*, III, 258.

³⁹University of Nottingham Library, Clifton MSS, 631. Earl of Exeter's correspondence.

⁴⁰Richard Cust, 'Charles I, the Privy Council, and the Forced Loan', *Journal of British Studies* 24, no. 2 (1985), 216.

⁴¹John Forster, *Sir John Eliot: A Biography, 1590-1632* (London: Longman, Roberts & Green, 1864), 13.

⁴²John Eliot, *De Jure Majestatis and Letter-book*, ed. A. B. Grosart, 2 vols. (privately printed, 1882), II, 146.

⁴³Russell, *Parliaments and English Politics*, 382.

⁴⁴TNA, Montagu MS 3, 207. Montagu's statement of support for the Forced Loan.

it.⁴⁵ Although there is little evidence of Knightley's position within this group or his particular reasoning, this is when his overall political stance is most clear.

Knightley seems to have been part of a wider Northamptonshire Puritan movement against the charge, with his close associates Sir Erasmus Dryden, Sir John Pickering, and John Isham also among the number of Northamptonshire men caught up in this Forced Loan dispute.⁴⁶ Summoned before the Privy Council alongside these men for refusing to pay the Forced Loan, Knightley refused to kneel, so that he should not 'seem to acknowledge a fault, and crave mercy where he is not guilty'.⁴⁷ Knightley was subsequently committed to the Fleet prison,⁴⁸ 'not for the refusal of the subsidy, but, as it is said, for not kneeling at the council table when he was called to answer'.⁴⁹

Although his refusal to kneel was a symbolic gesture of opposition to the government, it might be considered an indication of the moderate nature of his opposition. He did not hold out long to pay his Forced Loan charge, unlike other notable refusers. In correspondence of 1628 between Thomas Scott and Sir Dudley Digges about how to behave in the face of a Privy Council appearance, Knightley's example was raised admiringly as a model of how to present opposition to the authority of the government.⁵⁰ Digges is known as a moderate critic of the Caroline government, so this might indicate a recognition of Knightley's actions as an ideal 'moderate' sort of protest. This case tells us something about Knightley's political affiliation, but also about how certain gestures and actions could be appropriated and framed by third parties in the febrile political environment of early Stuart England.

Knightley's activities as a local officeholder during the Personal Rule offer a window into how an individual's national politico-religious views interacted with the local politics of their county. Mark Goldie has famously written about the degree of independence which the holders of early modern local offices perceived themselves to have.⁵¹ With the capacity of the crown to exert its will almost entirely reliant upon the collaboration of local officeholders performing their duties in the interstices of their day-to-day lives, officeholders were afforded significant latitude in the discharge of their duties. Knightley, who was a JP from 1620 to 1626 and from 1628 until his death in 1639, likely felt a degree of conflict between his distaste for the government's policies and his duty as an officeholder to enforce them. Although he personally enforced many of the government's measures, including the financially exactive ones which he did not appear to agree with, he did not do so uniformly throughout the period. Knightley even petitioned to have the level of some payments reduced in his locality. The degree to which such behaviour was politically charged, or would even have constituted an aberration for a loyal local officeholder, is doubtful. Kenneth Fincham and Peter

⁴⁵Richard Cust, *The Forced Loan and English Politics, 1626–1628* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1987), 225.

⁴⁶Thomas Birch and Robert Folkestone Williams, *The Court and Times of Charles the First* (London: Henry Colburn, 1848), I, 191.

⁴⁷*Ibid.*, 190.

⁴⁸*Acts of the Privy Council of England*, 42, 1627 (London: HMSO, 1938), 430.

⁴⁹Birch and Williams, *Court and Times of Charles the First*, I, 188.

⁵⁰Cesare Cuttica, 'Thomas Scott of Canterbury (1566–1635): Patriot, Civic Radical, Puritan', *History of European Ideas* 34, no. 4 (2008), 475–89.

⁵¹Mark Goldie, 'The Unacknowledged Republic: Officeholding in Early Modern England', in *The Politics of the Excluded, c. 1500–1850*, ed. Tim Harris (Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan, 2001), 153–94.

Lake have drawn attention to the perils of historians seeking to uncover ideological opposition to the government in the localities through official sources.⁵² It was not unusual for local officeholders, even those who supported the regime, to abandon their duties occasionally or even break the law from time to time. Knightley might be identified as belonging to the same tradition that John Morrill identified the Cheshire county grandee and MP Sir William Brereton as belonging to.⁵³ Brereton combined a fierce Puritanical radicalism in national politics with an aversion to unrest and rebellion in local affairs, leading Morrill to brand him a constitutional quietist, whose primary concern was the rule of law.

In November 1635, Knightley submitted himself to the council for the neglect of his musters in Northamptonshire and was voluntarily discharged from this role.⁵⁴ This appears to represent another moment in which he took political objection to a duty forced upon him. Esther Cope has written about the politicisation of muster fee payment in Shropshire in the 1630s, and there is evidence that men in Knightley's orbit appeared to harbour ill-will towards the muster.⁵⁵ In 1632, Sir Arthur Hesilrige was ordered to appear before the Privy Council for a complaint that he had refused to pay the levies made for the fee of the muster master, as well as the charges of the muster.⁵⁶ His appearance featured a notably ill-tempered argument with the loyalist Sir John Skeffington, resulting in a sentence of imprisonment, which he avoided by agreeing to pay his muster master's fees. Hesilrige's objection in this case was political. However, Knightley's obligation lay on the other side of the ledger to Hesilrige's, and he was not expected to pay the muster. Moreover, there is not much evidence for muster-masters having employed resignation as a political tool in this period. Musters were typically excused when they were impossible or otherwise particularly difficult to complete, as was the case when John Browne, who would later be revealed as a staunch royalist at the outbreak of the Civil War, requested to have his musters excused in the 1620s.⁵⁷ It would not be appropriate to draw any political conclusions from this particular action by Knightley.

Knightley's rather nuanced relationship with officeholding continued in his handling of the imposition of Ship Money in the latter part of the 1630s. Although supportive of attempts to reassess his locality, he also used his position as a JP to quell local opposition to the payment of Ship Money itself.⁵⁸ When Northamptonshire man Richard Smith reacted angrily to being distrained for 50s of Ship Money in September 1636, attacking those attempting to distrain him while pronouncing the charge illegal, it was Knightley, as the JP responsible, who dealt with him. Knightley 'sharply reproved' Smith and stated that, if allowed, 'he would punish him'.⁵⁹ Knightley was apparently

⁵²Kenneth Fincham and Peter Lake, 'The Ecclesiastical Policy of King James I', *Journal of British Studies* 24, no. 2 (1985), 169–207.

⁵³John Morrill, 'Sir William Brereton and England's Wars of Religion', *Journal of British Studies* 24, no. 3 (1985), 311–32.

⁵⁴*Calendar of State Papers Domestic, 1635–36* (London: HMSO, 1866), 489.

⁵⁵Esther S. Cope, 'Politics without Parliament: The Dispute about Muster Masters' Fees in Shropshire in the 1630s', *Huntington Library Quarterly* 45, no. 4 (1982), 271–84.

⁵⁶*Calendar of State Papers Domestic, 1631–33* (London: HMSO, 1862), 445–56.

⁵⁷Kevin Sharpe, *The Personal Rule of Charles I* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1992), 29.

⁵⁸TNA, SP 16/338, fols. 2, 21, 211, Correspondence relating to Ship Money income in Northamptonshire.

⁵⁹*Calendar of State Papers Domestic, 1636–37* (London: HMSO, 1867), 151.

willing to exercise his duties as a local officeholder when they required him to enforce payment of the charge. The claim in Knightley's *History of Parliament* entry that he was involved in a petition against the assessment of Ship Money in Northamptonshire obscures the complexity of this particular episode in the local politics of the 1630s. Analysis of Knightley's place in this controversy reveals part of his complex relationship with the centre.

Although conflict over the payment of Ship Money had traditionally been a proving ground for historians seeking a basis for the Civil War in 'Stuart Absolutism',⁶⁰ in *Revolt of the Provinces*, John Morrill proposed a then-groundbreaking approach to understanding the politics of Ship Money disputes. He suggested that, contrary to the arguments of previous political historians, many disputes over the terms of assessments were not really signals about attitudes to national government, but were instead the product of genuine local concern.⁶¹ It was not unknown across early Stuart England for some assessors, even among those who were outwardly loyal, to openly accept that Ship Money was an encumbrance whose impact on communities should be minimised or mitigated. Peter Lake has noted that this was the case in Cheshire in the mid-1630s, where the royalist sheriff Sir Thomas Aston brought a jurisdictional challenge to the assessment to the council and was able to present himself locally as a champion of the more equitable distribution of Ship Money's burden, while appearing as an effective agent for its collection in the eyes of the national government.⁶² Opposition of this kind was not necessarily treated as hostile by the national government, especially when it was thought that a locally satisfactory settlement might allow for the smoother collection of the charge. By applying this analysis to Knightley, who enforced the collection of Ship Money but was happy to support counter-assessments of the charge, one can resolve some of the apparent contradictions in his political character. This leads one towards consideration of Knightley as something of a moderate Puritan county man who, like Richard Grosvenor, attempted to strike a balance between loyalty and local interests.

Nonetheless, the level of local Laudian concern which Knightley's Ship Money dispute prompted indicates how contentious the distinctions between loyal and disloyal dispute about the assessment of Ship Money were in the period. It illustrates how deeply politico-religious conflict had influenced the political outlooks of some of the most extreme Laudians and Puritans by the middle point of the Personal Rule. In Northamptonshire, this is apparent in the words of a particularly hostile band of local loyalists, who were quick to level accusations of treason against Knightley for his perceived infractions. In the contemporary correspondence of two local Laudians, Dr Robert Sibthorpe and Sir John Lambe, it was asserted that Knightley's activities in 1636 amounted to an attempt to stir up opposition to the principle of Ship Money and, by extension, the legitimate authority of the government. Both men were staunch supporters of the king's right to demand payment from the population without parliamentary approval. Sibthorpe had been impeached in the House of Lords in 1628 on the back of a highly publicised assize sermon of 1627 on the value of passive obedience to

⁶⁰Samuel Gardiner, *History of England from the Accession of James I to the Outbreak of the Civil War, 1603–1642*, (London, 1884), VIII:67, 80–85.

⁶¹Morrill, *Revolt in the Provinces*, 24–27.

⁶²Lake, 'Ship Money in Cheshire', 46.

taxation, in a process led by John Pym.⁶³ He had subsequently been pardoned by the king. Lambe and Sibthorpe had together lobbied Charles in the 1620s to take a tougher anti-Puritan stance on the basis of Forced Loan refusal.⁶⁴ In their correspondence, Knightley is accused of attempting to undermine peaceable relations in the wider county. In March 1636, Sibthorpe reported that Knightley had raised a ‘clamour’ against the assessment of Ship Money in Northamptonshire by supporting a petition for a counter-assessment from the hundred of Guilsborough.⁶⁵ By doing this, Sibthorpe claimed, ‘Mr Knightley still endeavours to nourish contention’. In another letter from Sibthorpe to Lambe of March 1636, Knightley is accused of having used his lawyerly expertise to assist the former sheriff Sir John Dryden (Sir Erasmus Dryden’s son) and Thomas Bacon in producing a certificate to verify a counter-assessment for the payment of Ship Money in Sibthorpe’s parish of Burton Latimer.⁶⁶ Knightley is referred to in one of Sibthorpe’s letters as one of Dryden’s ‘Puritan high constables’, and claims that Dryden had visited Knightley’s home at Preston Capes, staying ‘from seven o’clock in the morning till five at night’ one Wednesday in order to plan their opposition to the payment of Ship Money.⁶⁷ Ship Money was a locus for local conspiratorial thinking about Puritans during the Personal Rule, including Knightley.

A clarificatory letter from Dryden and Charles Cockayne, then sheriff of Northamptonshire, argues the opposite position from Sibthorpe - that this dispute was not about opposition to the payment of Ship Money in principle, but the result of confusion between two rival assessments produced in response to complaints by a wide range of men about a ‘very unequal’ assessment.⁶⁸ This was the unrest which Sibthorpe accused Bacon (along with Knightley) of having instigated in the first place. Cockayne states that he had assembled a local committee to produce an improved assessment, but its failure led to two rival assessments and a series of misunderstandings. He is adamant throughout the letter that neither Knightley nor the rest of the group had resisted payment or encouraged others to do so. This would fit with John Morrill and Kevin Sharpe’s revisionist view of the nature of most Ship Money conflicts of the period: that they were largely not outwardly ideological conflicts between court and country, but rather revolved around more quotidian issues such as the size of an individual’s personal assessment or the proportion of the overall burden their locality had to raise.⁶⁹ Regardless of the truth of Sibthorpe’s allegations, the nature of this dispute reveals much about how national politics had come to infiltrate the localities. It is difficult to know the extent to which any conspiracy was a figment of these fervent loyalists’ imaginations. Either way, it is a sign of the emergence of as yet unexpressed fissures in English local political life. For Sibthorpe, Knightley was just one among a larger group of hated local Puritan officeholders engaged in a conspiracy against the king’s service in the county.

⁶³ John Fielding, ‘Sibthorpe, Robert (d. 1662)’, *Oxford Dictionary of National Biography* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2004).

⁶⁴ Noah Millstone, ‘Bishop Williams among the Puritans, 1621–1640’, *English Historical Review* 140, no. 606 (2025), 1005.

⁶⁵ *Calendar of State Papers Domestic, 1636–37*, 510.

⁶⁶ *Ibid.*, 348.

⁶⁷ Huntington Library, Stowe Temple Papers, STT 1880. Correspondence from Robert Sibthorpe.

⁶⁸ TNA, SP 16/317/46. Correspondence from Sir John Dryden.

⁶⁹ Sharpe, *Personal Rule of Charles I*, 591–93.

Knightley's support of those organising against collection can be understood through the revisionist framework. But even if his objection ran to the very principle of Ship Money, that alone would not fix his politics precisely. Cases exist where objection to the principle of Ship Money was not conceived of as treasonous in and of itself. The judge, Sir Richard Hutton, declared in a judgement of 1638 that the levying of Ship Money without parliamentary assent was illegal - an action that undoubtedly strengthened wider opposition to the charge.⁷⁰ Like Knightley, Hutton was pursued by individual Laudians on suspicion of treason. In Hutton's case, this took the form of being openly accused of treason in Westminster Hall by a clergyman. Despite this, Hutton retained the broad confidence of the crown - which prosecuted his accuser - and the king, who referred to Hutton as 'the honest judge' even after these accusations. It was possible to tread the middle way in early Stuart politics while opposing Ship Money in principle.

Sibthorpe and Lambe's quarrel with Knightley bears analysis through the lens of the 'county community'. In his study of Tudor Suffolk, Diarmaid MacCulloch has shown how the initially aggressive and highly self-assertive style of local officeholders in the early sixteenth century had, by the dawn of the seventeenth century, been gradually replaced by a new style of local government that was highly focused on the appearance of harmony and mutual consent, often promoted through conspicuous displays of unity.⁷¹ The allegation of 'faction' in local government was thus a very serious one indeed. An obsession with consensual local government was a feature of late Tudor political culture, which, as Richard Cust has argued, was only strengthened in the early Stuart period.⁷² As such, an explosion of factional disagreement of this sort represented a departure from the political unity expected of men in this position. It is notable that, while the ideological coordinates of the Laudians involved in this case were not identical to those of the central government, they looked to import national conflicts into the conduct of local office. This does not align with the views of historians such as Kevin Sharpe, who have sought to separate the secular politics of the period from its ideological divides. Although it was not entirely unknown for disputes between local officeholders in this period to break out into open hostility, it is striking that at least a few participants in this Northamptonshire Ship Money dispute appear to have perceived there to be a religio-political element to the conflict. The deeply Puritan Robert Woodford, who was acting as clerk for his friend Thomas Bacon, would write in his diary that as he went 'to the Counsell table with Mr. Bacon and I am apt to think that Dr. Sibthorpe will therefore set himselfe against me and ruine me... [oh Lord] thou must deliver me from the mouth of the lyon and from the fingers of the wicked'.⁷³ This was a rare moment when the ideological conflict that was brewing during the Personal Rule broke free from the 'thin mask' which Peter Lake has claimed usually concealed it in the day-to-day

⁷⁰Wilfrid Prest, 'Hutton, Sir Richard (bap. 1561, d. 1639)', *Oxford Dictionary of National Biography* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2004).

⁷¹Diarmaid MacCulloch, *Suffolk and the Tudors: Politics and Religion in an English County, 1500-1600* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1986).

⁷²Richard Cust, 'Honour, Rhetoric and Political Culture', in *Political Culture and Cultural Politics in Early Modern England: Essays Presented to David Underdown*, eds. Susan D. Amussen and Mark A. Kishlansky (Manchester: Manchester University Press, 1995), 84-111.

⁷³John Fielding, 'Opposition to the Personal Rule of Charles I: The Diary of Robert Woodford, 1637-1641', *Historical Journal* 31, no. 4 (1988), 785.

business of government.⁷⁴

Sibthorpe's intimation that Dryden's association with Knightley rendered Dryden an object of legitimate suspicion indicates just how important social connections were thought to be when determining political allegiance in the county during the Personal Rule. John Fielding points to Robert Woodford's diary as evidence of how ideas and principles from the national Puritan group 'percolated down to the provinces and found support there'.⁷⁵ Fielding is even able to trace specific instances of information travelling through political-social channels from the national Puritan conversation into county-level Puritan discourse. He points to a case where Woodford became aware of a 1637 rumour of the king's illness, and recorded his earnest wish that it might 'move his hart to call a parliament which (being directed by thee) may conclude uppon wholesome lawes for the Kingdome and may redress exhorbitancyes'. This suggestion gives credence to the idea that the politics of a Northamptonshire man like Knightley can be understood by reference to his personal connections with a national Puritan elite.

Fielding has suggested that Knightley's personal connections outside his county are important to understanding his politics, writing that he belonged to a group of men involved in organising 'non-parliamentary resistance to court policy from the 1620s onward'.⁷⁶ One of the key figures in national Puritan life connected to Knightley was John Pym, whom Conrad Russell suggested lived with Knightley at Fawsley for a significant part of the Personal Rule. Pym was a highly influential individual whose political placement as a strong parliamentarian was revealed after the Personal Rule. Russell has further suggested that this lack of a county connection and nomadic lifestyle afforded Pym a degree of independence that was central to his success when parliament returned: as a consequence, 'he was, then, able to be uniquely his own man in his contributions to debate in the House of Commons'.⁷⁷

Primary evidence about Pym's life between the parliaments of 1614 and 1640 is scarce, and Pym's entries in the *Oxford Dictionary of National Biography* and the *History of Parliament* do not pinpoint his precise whereabouts during the Personal Rule. John Morrill has argued that 'all we can say with confidence is that he can be regularly glimpsed in the relaxed presence of the malcontent and Puritan peers'.⁷⁸ In correspondence of July 1638, Pym wrote about returning to the country in which he had spent 'the most part of these two years last past', meaning between 1636 and 1638.⁷⁹ Although Pym does not specify the part of the country to which he refers, Conrad Russell suggests that this refers to Northamptonshire.⁸⁰ Supporting this, the letters written by Pym's teenage daughter Dorothy to her older brother Charles during this two-year period were

⁷⁴Peter Lake, 'The Moderate and Irenic Case for Religious War: Joseph Hall's Via Media in Context', in Amussen and Kishlansky, *Political Culture and Cultural Politics*, 55–83.

⁷⁵Fielding, 'Opposition to the Personal Rule', 783.

⁷⁶*The Diary of Robert Woodford, 1637–1641*, ed. John Fielding, Camden Fifth Series, 42 (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2012), 88.

⁷⁷Conrad Russell, *Unrevolutionary England, 1603–1642* (London: Hambledon Press, 1990), 207.

⁷⁸John Morrill, 'The Unweariability of Mr Pym: Influence and Eloquence in the Long Parliament', in Amussen and Kishlansky, *Political Culture and Cultural Politics*, 21.

⁷⁹*Calendar of State Papers Domestic, 1638*, 571.

⁸⁰Russell, *Unrevolutionary England*, 207.

marked as having come from Fawsley, on the occasion where she included an address.⁸¹

Christopher Thompson has doubted Russell's claim about Pym's whereabouts during the Personal Rule on the basis that Pym spent a more significant part of his time in London between 1636 and 1638 than Russell indicates.⁸² Indeed, evidence in the Papers of Sir John Bankes at the Bodleian Library shows that Pym was granted leave to remain in London indefinitely from 1636 to conduct the business of the Providence Island Company, following lobbying by the Earl of Holland, the governor of the company and a close associate of Buckingham during his life, who would eventually join the king's side in the Civil War.⁸³ This does not necessarily disprove the notion that Pym spent a significant amount of time at Fawsley, nor does it preclude the possibility that Pym was able to make a place for himself in the county politics of Northamptonshire. Anthony Milton's recent study of the diary of Samuel Torshell, a Cheshire Puritan divine who spent a significant period of the 1630s in the capital but still retained his connection with the politics of his county, provides an example of a person retaining political grounding in the period despite the nomadic existence that Pym experienced in the 1630s.⁸⁴ However, the Journal of the Providence Island Company - in whose operations both Knightley and Pym were involved - indicates that Pym was living a nomadic life in this period. The company met in different places over the period, and records of company meetings attended by Pym between 1636 and 1639 give times when Pym was certainly in Northamptonshire and Warwickshire, in many cases in the company of Knightley.⁸⁵ Knightley and Pym appear to have spent a notable amount of time together, likely with Pym staying at Fawsley, and Pym's presence at Fawsley in that period indicates Knightley's high degree of importance within the national Puritan movement.

The purpose of this chapter has been to illustrate the connection between Knightley's local political life and his place on the national political scene. Pym represents a clear link between the two. Connections were drawn between Knightley's homes in Fawsley and Preston Capes and the planning of Puritan political action in both contemporary loyalist writing and in historical accounts of the period written from a royalist standpoint. In his *History of the Rebellion*, Clarendon referred to the scene at Fawsley during the Personal Rule as a 'kind of classis' from which the activities of a broader Puritan political grouping were organised.⁸⁶ The royalist pamphleteer Robert Chestlin's conspiratorial 1641 account of the antebellum organisation of the Puritan social elite, *Persecutio Undecima*, suggested that one of Knightley's Northamptonshire homes was a principal centre of coordination for this group. Chestlin wrote 'heard some of [his] Neighbours in Buckinghamshire say' that the leadership of the parliamentary cause 'had their Counsel Tables, sitting in . . . Knightly's House in Northamptonshire, Lord Sayes House, wherein was a room and passage, which his servants were

⁸¹Beinecke Library, Yale University, Sir Charles Pym Papers, OSB MSS 17, Correspondence from Dorothy Pym.

⁸²Christopher Thompson, Email correspondence with author, 21 March 2026.

⁸³Bodleian Library, MS Bankes 65/1, fol. 16, correspondence between Holland and Bankes.

⁸⁴Anthony Milton, 'Growing Opposition? Puritan Cheshire in Laudian London: The Diary of Samuel Torshell, 1638-9', in *Religion, Politics and the Public Sphere, 1500-1850*, eds. David Como and Michael Questier (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2025), 160-85.

⁸⁵TNA, CO 124/2, Journal of the Providence Island Company.

⁸⁶Edward Hyde, Earl of Clarendon, *The History of the Rebellion and Civil Wars in England*, ed. W. D. Macray, 6 vols. (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1888), I, 183.

prohibited to come near, where great noises and talkings have been heard'.⁸⁷ This allegation, like Sibthorpe's against Knightley, appears to be based on hearsay. Although Knightley was connected to this group, the precise nature of these ties has to be further examined to come to a judgement on his political views. Moreover, these social connections form only one part of Knightley's engagement with his Puritan community, the remainder of which was concentrated in other areas of his life that were less explicitly connected with the national political scene.

⁸⁷Robert Chestlin, *Persecutio Undecima: The Eleventh Persecution* (London, 1648), 53.

Chapter 2: Religion and the Patronage of Divines

In his 1992 study *The Personal Rule of Charles I* Kevin Sharpe lamented that, while historians had been eager to uncover evidence of cooperation between the Puritan peers who came to dominate political life in the 1640s, the level of meaningful political organisation among the Puritan gentry of the 1630s remained understudied. Sharpe pointed to two Northamptonshire families as examples of this less-researched group: the Knightleys and their friends the Drydens of Canons Ashby.⁸⁸ Although J. T. Cliffe's survey of the Puritan gentry offered a foundation on which one could examine these families' particular religious lives, most notable for their habit of providing refuge to persecuted non-conformist Puritan ministers, Sharpe noted that little had been written on their collaboration in religion and politics.

This chapter seeks to address that gap by drawing together a record of Knightley's religious associations during the Personal Rule. Having returned from London in the 1610s after deciding against a career at the bar, Knightley quickly ingratiated himself within Northamptonshire's Puritan *milieu* in his own right. Some of the Knightleys' neighbours, like the Dryden family, were among this group. In 1618, Knightley succeeded to the ownership of the principal family estate, Fawsley. His management of the chapel there enables a clear examination of his particularly reformed religion and its interactions with the dominant political-religious currents of the period. One of the principal approaches taken here is to examine Knightley's relationships with, and through, priests. As John Fielding has pointed out, there was a pattern in Northamptonshire of panels of highly reformed clergymen hostile to the Laudian 'new conformity' acting as private advisers to local peers and members of the godly gentry.⁸⁹ Nicholas Tyacke has described Fawsley as one of the loci of this phenomenon - 'almost a Puritan shrine' in the 1620s and 1630s, where 'the godly went on pilgrimage... sometimes even to die'.⁹⁰ The two men Tyacke principally had in mind were Knightley's long-time ministers John Preston and John Dod, both of whom also ministered to a constellation of Puritans of many kinds, as well as to conformist Anglicans. Where Knightley's pedigree and marriage might invite one to see him as a Puritan non-conformist of the most committed kind, it does not appear that his associations were limited to the most radical Puritan groups, nor to those aligned with organised opposition to the king. As in the previous chapter, I will suggest the breadth of Knightley's network, that included members of most factions of the godly community, contradicts the existing historiographical picture of him as a Puritan radical. This is exemplified by his close relationship with the divine John Preston, who, although accused of having been a non-conformist Puritan by some Victorian historians, was an outwardly moderate and conforming Puritan throughout the 1620s, and an occasional personal cleric to Charles, then the prince of Wales.⁹¹

Although the previous chapter sought to give a sense of Knightley's political placement by

⁸⁸Kevin Sharpe, *The Personal Rule of Charles I* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1992), 745.

⁸⁹John Fielding, 'Conformists, Puritans and the Church Courts: The Diocese of Peterborough, 1603–42' (unpublished PhD thesis, University of Birmingham, 1989), 42.

⁹⁰Nicholas Tyacke, *The Fortunes of English Puritanism, 1603–1640* (London: Dr Williams's Trust, 1990), 16.

⁹¹Jonathan Moore, 'Preston, John (1587–1628)', *Oxford Dictionary of National Biography* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2004).

reference to his social connections and expressly political activism, one cannot escape the conclusion that most of the divides in Early Stuart politics were religious. The link between religion and politics throughout the period of the Personal Rule is widely recognised, and holds true long before the labels of Presbyterian and Independent divided parliament. In his recent study of Laudianism, which characterises Laudianism as a fairly complete political ideology in contrast to Sharpe's view, Peter Lake posits that the Personal Rule was a period of conflict between two relatively coherent political-religious movements, Laudianism and Puritanism.⁹² Religious politics was not confined to the distant and theoretical world of 'ideology'; it defined many of the everyday political disputes of the time. Nicholas Tyacke points to the final meeting of the House of Commons in March 1629, with 'Arminianism yoked together with tonnage and poundage as the two currently outstanding grievances', as an example of how much religion was a quotidian political issue in the period.⁹³ Studies of how this ideological conflict was expressed have taken an increasingly local form, ranging from Noah Millstone's investigation of Laudian conflict in early Stuart Ipswich⁹⁴ to Peter Lake and Isaac Stephens's highly relevant study of religious conflict in early Stuart Northamptonshire.⁹⁵ Discussion of religious discord in this period has clear wider importance, since, depending on whose history of the Civil War is being read, religious strife can be considered as the fundamental cause of the conflict, an adjunct to its real cause, or something in between.⁹⁶

Knightley was a Puritan of some standing. This is evidenced not only by his parliamentary contributions, as discussed in the previous chapter, but also by his actions within his Puritan religious community. In the autobiography he includes in the introduction to his *Lives of Sundry Eminent Persons in this Later Age*, the non-conformist divine Samuel Clarke recounts an occasion on which, when faced with a challenging visitation, Knightley was able to save Clarke's career through a conveniently timed representation to a conformist bishop.⁹⁷ Perhaps this was an example of the 'kind of fraternity' that Clarendon described as typical of the classis he suggests was behind the revolutionary cause in seventeenth-century England. Ann Hughes has written about the tightly bound social connections between elite Puritan laity and their vicars, noting the value of studying these networks of 'parliamentary-Puritan connection' as a means of understanding private views of the king's government in an environment with 'no forum for concerted criticism or opposition'.⁹⁸ By examining Knightley's engagement with a wide range of Puritans from across the spectrum of

⁹²Peter Lake, *On Laudianism: Piety, Polemic and Politics During the Personal Rule of Charles I* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2023).

⁹³Nicholas Tyacke, 'The Nature of 'the Powers that Be': Politico-Religious Thought 1637–53 and its Antecedents', in *Religion, Politics and the Public Sphere, 1500–1850*, eds. David Como and Michael Questier (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2025), 264.

⁹⁴Noah Millstone, 'Space, place and Laudianism in early Stuart Ipswich', in *Connecting Centre and Locality: Political Communication in Early Modern England*, eds. Chris R. Kyle and Jason Peacey (Manchester: Manchester University Press, 2020), 66–93.

⁹⁵Peter Lake and Isaac Stephens, *Scandal and Religious Identity in Early Stuart England: A Northamptonshire Maid's Tragedy* (Woodbridge: The Boydell Press, 2015).

⁹⁶*England's Wars of Religion Revisited*, eds. C. W. A. Prior and G. Burgess (Farnham: Ashgate, 2011), 1–25.

⁹⁷Samuel Clarke, *The Lives of Sundry Eminent Persons in this Later Age, in Two Parts: I. Of Divines; II. Of Nobility and Gentry of Both Sexes* (London, 1683), 153.

⁹⁸Ann Hughes, 'Thomas Dugard and his Circle in the 1630s — A 'Parliamentary-Puritan' Connexion?', *Historical Journal* 29, no. 4 (1986), 774.

reformed early Stuart political belief, from those who were instrumental in agitating against the government, to those who supported it, one can test two opposed historiographical readings of early Stuart Puritanism. The first position is held by historians such as Patrick Collinson, who identify Puritanism as an offshoot of the Protestant mainstream in the period.⁹⁹ The second claim is that of historians like Sharpe, who identify early Stuart Puritanism as an extremist subculture with a necessarily political bent that was almost entirely separate from the mainstream of the national church.¹⁰⁰

Tom Webster has suggested that networks of association present a valuable entry point into the operation and distribution of influence within communities of the godly, including in their relationships with the Puritan gentry.¹⁰¹ By adopting this approach, one can recreate the overlapping political and religious ties that bound Knightley to co-religionists in his locality and across the nation. Peter Lake has suggested that the absence of a parliament significantly affected how opponents of government measures could frame their activism: opposition expressed through the king's own council, before the High Commission, or at court was depressed by the decline of parliamentary activism in London.¹⁰² As a consequence, opponents of the government became more reliant on informal 'networks' of opposition to coordinate. Knightley's experience appears to add a degree of complexity to this understanding. While his religion brought him close to a good number of rebellious individuals, both the rebellious peers whom John Adamson placed at the centre of his reading of the English Civil War¹⁰³ and the MPs upon whom revisionists like Russell focused, religion also brought him close with Puritans who did not join the parliamentary cause at the outset of the English Civil War.

Religion was the unifying principle behind many of the most significant political and personal relationships in Knightley's life. A brief survey of his most intimate personal relationships might lead one to view him as a non-conformist Puritan of the highest order. His uncle and predecessor at Fawsley, Sir Valentine Knightley, vigorously petitioned against the suspension of non-conforming ministers in Northamptonshire under James I, and was removed from the commission of the peace for the infraction.¹⁰⁴ As well as being a scion of a well-known non-conformist Puritan family, Knightley was married to Bridget, the daughter of the famous Warwickshire non-conformist Puritan agitator Sir Thomas Lucy.¹⁰⁵ Knightley's personal religious beliefs during the Personal Rule are difficult to establish in isolation because, aside from having failed to set up an east-end railed altar at Fawsley in 1637, there is little evidence of his religious worship.¹⁰⁶

⁹⁹Patrick Collinson, *The Religion of Protestants: The Church in English Society, 1559–1625* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1982).

¹⁰⁰Sharpe, *Personal Rule of Charles I*.

¹⁰¹Tom Webster, *Godly Clergy in Early Stuart England: The Caroline Puritan Movement, c. 1620–1643* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1997).

¹⁰²Lake, 'Collection of Ship Money'.

¹⁰³John Adamson, *The Noble Revolt: The Overthrow of Charles I* (London: Weidenfeld & Nicolson, 2007).

¹⁰⁴*A History of the County of Northampton*, 2 (London: Victoria County History, 1906), 51.

¹⁰⁵Ann Hughes, *Politics, Society and Civil War in Warwickshire, 1620–1660* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1987), 65.

¹⁰⁶Fielding, 'Conformists, Puritans and the Church Courts', 146–61.

Looking towards Knightley's Puritan community allows for the further examination of his religious placement. Knightley existed within a county community that was divided not only between Puritans and Laudians, but also amongst Puritans themselves between moderate conformist Puritans and radical non-conformist Puritans. There was a well-developed network of reformed lectureships across the county, many of which were subject to suppression in the second half of the 1630s on suspicion of rebellious behaviour. Knightley patronised the Daventry lecture, which often drew upon the non-conformist ministers associated with Fawsley.¹⁰⁷

In large part thanks to the work of John Fielding and Tom Webster, there is a well-researched corpus of historical writing on the divisions within the community of the godly in Northamptonshire during the early Stuart period. As Fielding has shown, the rise of Laudianism during the Personal Rule contributed to the intensification of intra-Puritan tensions in the county. Some more moderate Puritan ministers such as Joseph Bentham, whose patron was Montagu, accepted the demands of an increasingly assertive and hostile ecclesiastical authority. Others adopted a more defiant stance, claiming that ceremonies and practices they had previously tolerated had been rendered unbearable by the increasingly objectionable Laudian tenor of the church. Such disputes were protracted and bitter in Northamptonshire.¹⁰⁸ The county contained a large community of non-conformist Puritans who were hostile to the ordinary practices of the established church. It is a testament to the strength of these non-conformist congregations that, even at Burton Latimer, where Sibthorpe held his parish, parishioners (including Bacon) resisted the imposition of an altar rail throughout the 1630s.¹⁰⁹ Fielding has noted that alterations to the prayer book, the encouragement of extempore prayer, sermon gadding, and private fasts were all central to the life of a large proportion of the godly in Northamptonshire during this period.¹¹⁰ Indeed, he suggests that a typical congregation in early Stuart Northamptonshire was more reformed than average.

Fielding suggests that Knightley and his close associates, the Drydens, had staked out their position in this internal conflict by hosting some of the most famous non-conformist Puritan ministers in the country, including Dod. In this way, Knightley might have belonged to the opposite side of an intra-community conflict as noted conforming Northamptonshire Puritans like Robert Bolton or Bentham (Montagu's priest). Aside from Knightley's aforementioned lobbying of Montagu for a harder line on Spain, the evidence for Knightley actively clashing with Montagu and his fellow co-religionists over this is scant. In her 2004 PhD thesis, Juliet Ingram suggested that a coded line in Bentham's 1635 tract *The Christian Conflict* listing examples of unjustified acts of enclosure, including 'L. inclosed by M. K', was a veiled attack on the covetousness of Knightley's Puritan grandfather, and thus upon his progeny.¹¹¹ This is not a particularly direct expression of hostility, nor is there evidence of a response from Knightley. Both of these men used much harsher language

¹⁰⁷Ibid., 160.

¹⁰⁸Ibid., Chapter 8.

¹⁰⁹John Fielding, 'Arminianism in the Localities: Peterborough Diocese, 1603–42', in *The Early Stuart Church, 1603–1642*, ed. Kenneth Fincham (Basingstoke: Macmillan, 1993), 93–113.

¹¹⁰Fielding, 'Conformists, Puritans and the Church Courts', Chapter 4.

¹¹¹Juliet Ingram, *The Conscience of the Community: The Character and Development of Clerical Complaint in Early Modern England* (PhD thesis, University of Warwick, 2004), 332.

towards non-Puritans openly, with Bolton famously suggesting the godly should avoid familiarity with the general Anglican communion and Bentham writing that ‘their society [was] dangerous and infectious’.¹¹² The degree to which Knightley actually engaged in conflict with moderate Puritans is doubtful.

The effect of the Laudian ideology upon people’s relationships with political authority is apparent if one considers some of Knightley’s local political opponents detailed in the previous chapter. Sibthorpe, who had preached a notorious sermon in defence of the Forced Loan at the Northamptonshire Assizes in 1627, is an example of the type of ideological warriors who were able to bring a religious dimension to the routine work of administration.¹¹³ Tim Harris takes a similar view of the Laudian clergymen-cum-cheerleaders of Charles’s fiscally exactive policies, characterising Sibthorpe’s assize sermon as part of a wider ‘ideological offensive’ plotted by the Caroline state against resistance to tax collection.¹¹⁴ In this light, it is no surprise that Sibthorpe expressed his religious politics so readily in the discussion of Knightley’s involvement in the counter-assessment petition for Ship Money.

Christopher Hill influentially suggested that the ‘spiritualisation of the household’ was one of the objectives to which early Stuart Puritans were committed.¹¹⁵ He cites John Dod and Robert Cleaver’s manual on household governance as proof of the Puritan belief in social interaction as an expression of religiosity.¹¹⁶ This idea that interpersonal relationships could be imbued with religious significance allows one to extract more meaning from the study of many Puritan groups. Ann Hughes’s study of the circle of clergymen centred on the patronage of Lord Brooke in Warwickshire in the 1620s and 1630s indicates just how well-developed and complex informal social networks of Puritans could become in the early Stuart period. She suggests that the protection of such a powerful lay patron, combined with the division of Warwickshire between two dioceses, encouraged ‘an alternative church structure independent of the ecclesiastical hierarchy’, amounting to ‘a quasi-Presbyterian clerical community’.¹¹⁷

The Caroline regime appears to have had concerns that clerics might act as vectors of political association during the Personal Rule. Clarendon’s near-contemporary historical account emphasises the convening power of clerical patronage among the Puritan group before the Civil War. He described Essex as ‘a County, upon the influence of the Earl of Warwick, and the power of his clergy’, in which the leaders of the parliamentary cause ‘most confided’.¹¹⁸ A similar concern about the transmission of political influence through religion, albeit with the direction of transmission reversed, was expressed in Archbishop Laud’s correspondence of 1634, which voiced the worry that

¹¹²Alexandra Walsham, ‘The Godly and Their Neighbours: Puritanism and Religious Pluralism in Early Modern England’, *Revue Française de Civilisation Britannique* 27, no. 3 (2022), 13.

¹¹³*Victoria History of Northampton*, 2, 51.

¹¹⁴Tim Harris, *Rebellion: Britain’s First Stuart Kings, 1567–1642* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2014), 252–62.

¹¹⁵Christopher Hill, *Society and Puritanism in Pre-Revolutionary England* (London: Mercury Books, 1966).

¹¹⁶Robert Cleaver and John Dod, *A Godly Forme of Houshold Government* (London: assigns of Thomas Man, 1630).

¹¹⁷Hughes, ‘Thomas Dugard and his Circle’, 771–93.

¹¹⁸Edward Hyde, Earl of Clarendon, *The History of the Rebellion and Civil Wars in England*, ed. W. D. Macray, 6 vols. (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1888), II, 369.

‘some Puritan justices of the peace have awed some of the clergy into opinions with themselves’.¹¹⁹

Examination of local lectureships offers another avenue for assessing Knightley’s religiosity. By the 1630s, ‘Puritan’ lectures were consistent flashpoints; opposition to lecturing, as indelibly associated with Puritanism, was something of a signature Laudian concern, and the Caroline regime had put down many lectureships, particularly in the diocese of Peterborough, where a number were suppressed during the later 1630s, with the result that the issue became a flashpoint between the godly and their enemies.¹²⁰ Knightley’s highly-reformed grandfather Sir Richard Knightley had supported the lecture at Towcester, and it appears that the younger Richard Knightley followed this example. This was one of the most reformed and radical of the Northamptonshire lectures, and adds credence to the suggestion that Knightley was one of the hottest kinds of Puritan.¹²¹ The Kettering combination lecture, which Knightley attended on occasion, has been identified by John Fielding as one of the more moderate Puritan exercises in the county, and is a testament to Knightley’s variety of religious experience. The lectureship’s functioning during the Personal Rule owed much to Montagu’s conformist-Puritan tendencies,¹²² and to the input of the Laudian bishop of Peterborough, William Piers.¹²³ A list of approved preachers survives in the State Papers, revealing the complex religious settlement in Knightley’s Northamptonshire, where highly reformed men preached alongside moderates and even Laudians like Sibthorpe.¹²⁴ It would not make sense to attempt to paint Knightley as an out-and-out non-conformist through association with a county whose prominent religious speakers, like Bentham, explicitly preached on the value of religious conformity.¹²⁵

Knightley was an eminent patron of godly vicars throughout the 1620s and the Personal Rule, and examination of the types of priest that he patronised provides some insight into his religious life. Moreover, with the shared patronage of divines forming a significant facet of elite Puritan sociability, these relationships offer another avenue through which Knightley’s position within the Puritan *milieu* can be assessed. In 1625, Knightley installed the noted, if ageing, Puritan minister John Dod, who had ministered to Sir Erasmus Dryden from around 1606 onward, as a permanent preacher at Fawsley. Although officially appointed vicar only in 1637, Dod had been the *de facto* vicar since around 1625. It is evidence of Dod’s religious standing within the Northamptonshire Puritan community, and Knightley’s importance as Dod’s gatekeeper, that, during the 1630–1631 negotiations between Sir John Isham and Sir Erasmus Dryden over a marriage settlement for their grandchildren, Knightley was sent for to act as an intermediary. One sticking point in the negotiations was Dryden’s insistence that any chaplain employed by the couple be approved by Knightley

¹¹⁹Sharpe, *Personal Rule of Charles I*, 745.

¹²⁰Fielding, ‘Conformists, Puritans and the Church Courts’, Chapter 4.

¹²¹A. Garfield, ‘The Progress of the Reformation in South Northamptonshire, c.1510–1750’ (PhD diss., University of Nottingham, 2016), 211.

¹²²Richard Cust, ‘Montagu, Edward, first Baron Montagu of Boughton (1562/3–1644)’, *Oxford Dictionary of National Biography* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2004).

¹²³Fielding, ‘Conformists, Puritans and the Church Courts’, 150–52.

¹²⁴TNA, SP 16/531, fol. 198, Undated list of nine approved preachers for the Kettering lecture.

¹²⁵Joseph Bentham, *The Societie of the Saints* (London, 1630), 35–36.

and Dod.¹²⁶ Knightley's correspondence with both of the marriage-brokers saved in the Isham family papers reveals the scope of his influence among the Northamptonshire gentry, in which he bluntly sets out certain terms within the marriage pact.¹²⁷ Knightley was clearly empowered within the local Puritan set by his association with Dod.

Through Dod, who was among the best-known and most prominent surviving late-sixteenth-century English Puritan divines, Knightley gained social access to a broader national Puritan community. Dod, one of the last living links to Elizabethan Puritanism by the 1630s, was described by the contemporary Puritan non-conformist Thomas Cartwright as the 'fittest man in England for a pastoral office',¹²⁸ and has accordingly been regarded, alongside Arthur Hildersham and John Ball, among the most influential non-conformist divines of the 1620s in the midland and north-western counties.¹²⁹ Dod was aligned with objection to the Forced Loan, though he was associated with a much more principled Forced Loan refuser than Knightley, Francis Barrington.¹³⁰ Barrington was imprisoned for far longer than Knightley ever was, and Dod visited him at the Fleet to preach his continued resistance.¹³¹

Dod was adept at navigating the networks of godly patronage in the counties and turning them to his advantage. It was through the recommendation of another godly gentleman of Northamptonshire, Sir John Pickering, that he came to the attention of the Isham family, who would become reliable clients for his ministry.¹³² The social position that Knightley and Dod, who remained technically vicar at Preston Capes for much of his time with Knightley, came to occupy within the wider English Puritan grouping is illustrated by the list of trustees Knightley appointed when, in 1630, he converted his impropriations into a trust to support Dod. This group comprised William Fiennes, first Viscount Saye and Sele, Christopher Sherland, John Hampden, John Pym, John Crewe, and Nathaniel Rich.¹³³ Upon the deaths of Sherland and Rich, Knightley substituted Edward Bagshaw and Sir Arthur Hesilrige.¹³⁴ That these men, many of whom belonged to the loose political association that J. H. Hexter described as the 'Bedford-Western gentry connection',¹³⁵ agreed to take on this duty attests not only to Knightley's social centrality, but also to the broader power of shared religious patronage as a convening force within this highly politically active group. Among this group of trustees were three of the 'Five Members' whom Charles attempted to arrest in January 1642.

However, it reveals the political heterodoxy of Knightley's Puritan grouping during the Personal

¹²⁶Isaac Stephens, *The Gentlewoman's Remembrance: Patriarchy, Piety, and Singlehood in Early Stuart England* (Manchester: Manchester University Press, 2017), 53.

¹²⁷IMSS, Northamptonshire Record Office, IC 3666, Letter from Richard Knightley to Sir John Isham.

¹²⁸Samuel Clarke, *A General Martyrology* (Glasgow: J. Galbraith, 1770), 319.

¹²⁹Elliot Vernon, *London presbyterians and the British revolutions, 1638-64*, (Manchester, England: Manchester University Press, 2021), 21.

¹³⁰Richard Cust, 'Charles I, the Privy Council, and the Forced Loan', *Journal of British Studies* 24, no. 2 (1985), 226.

¹³¹Richard Cust, *The Forced Loan and English Politics, 1626-1628* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1987), 300-01.

¹³²Lake and Stephens, *Northamptonshire Maid's Tragedy*, 296.

¹³³Fielding, 'Conformists, Puritans and the Church Courts', 218-19.

¹³⁴Northamptonshire Record Office, Knightley MSS, nos. 36, 38.

¹³⁵Hexter, *Reign of King Pym*, 78.

Rule that, among those trustees who lived to see the outbreak of the Civil War, several were moderate enough to not join the parliamentary group. These were Crewe and Bagshaw. Crewe, whom Clarendon called a man ‘of great moderation’,¹³⁶ was close enough to the crown to have been appointed to a position at court in 1638.¹³⁷ Bagshaw, for his part, maintained his resistance to the parliamentary cause despite being a Calvinist so critical of episcopacy that he was suspended as the Middle Temple’s Lent Reader by William Laud in 1639 for implicit criticism of the church.¹³⁸ Had Knightley lived until the outbreak of the Civil War, he might, like Bagshaw, have found a political position that compromised between his religion and his constitutional quietism. Dod, however, was a clearly non-conformist figure. In his preaching, he occasionally hinted at his own independent ecclesiology. When instructed in 1633 to read out the sentence of an ecclesiastical court upon a young fornicator within his congregation, Dod flatly refused, on the grounds that the young man had already taken penance within his own congregation before he was examined by the archdeacon.¹³⁹ He was reported to have been preaching heresy in the same year, and a visitation of 1635 described him as having refused to conform from as far back as 1607.¹⁴⁰ Samuel Clarke, who had known Knightley and Dod personally, writes of Dod’s time at Fawsley, describing him as having been kept ‘by the care and industry of Mr Richard Knightley. . . a worthy patriot’, at whose house Dod regularly hosted those who came to hear him preach.¹⁴¹ Clarke’s pointed description of Knightley as a ‘patriot’, Clarke himself living at Warwick Castle with Lord Brooke in a situation similar to Dod’s at Fawsley, likely represents a political point.¹⁴² It appears that Clarke, who was a Presbyterian supporter of the parliamentary cause by the 1640s, was attempting retrospectively to signal Knightley’s broad dissatisfaction with the government.

Preston, who had ministered to Knightley’s father and eventually died at Fawsley in 1628,¹⁴³ is a more religiously and politically complicated figure. He was a foundational figure within the Feoffees for Improvements, a national movement for Puritan patronage that brought together a broad social group of Puritans before the Civil War, and was called ‘probably the most prominent Puritan spokesman in the 1620s’ by Paul Seaver.¹⁴⁴ Preston was Master of Emmanuel College in the 1620s and, in that role, gained a central position within a network of clerics with representatives in many counties. Emmanuel had also allowed Preston access to influential members of the Puritan

¹³⁶Clarendon, *History of the Rebellion*, ed. Macray, III, 497.

¹³⁷J. M. Rigg and Sean Kelsey, ‘Crew, John, first Baron Crew (1597/8–1679)’, *Oxford Dictionary of National Biography* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2004).

¹³⁸P. R. N. Carter, ‘Bagshaw, Edward (1589/90–1662)’, *Oxford Dictionary of National Biography* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2004).

¹³⁹Webster, *Godly Clergy*, 234.

¹⁴⁰John Fielding, ‘Dod, John (1550–1645)’, *Oxford Dictionary of National Biography* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2004).

¹⁴¹Clarke, *General Martyrology*, 470.

¹⁴²Ann Hughes, ‘Clarke, Samuel (1599–1682)’, *Oxford Dictionary of National Biography* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2004).

¹⁴³Paul Seaver, *The Puritan Lectureships: The Politics of Religious Dissent, 1560–1662* (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 1970), 265.

¹⁴⁴Paul Seaver, ‘Puritan Preachers and their Patrons’ in *Religious Politics in Post-Reformation England*, ed. Kenneth Fincham and Peter Lake, (Woodbridge: Boydell & Brewer, 2006), 141.

laity, and he had gotten to know the Earl of Warwick by tutoring his son there.¹⁴⁵ As Tom Webster, who has described Northamptonshire as one of the counties subject to the repeated attention of the Emmanuel Puritan grouping, suggests, Preston was the ‘hub of a clerical community, receiving neophyte ministers into the world of Cambridge, guiding them through their education and into the overlapping communities of godly ministers in the provinces’.¹⁴⁶ However, Preston’s placement on the spectrum from Puritan conformist to non-conformist is unclear.

Preston’s diverse associations can be seen in a will he made in 1618, in which he divided his estate among a number of churchmen of many different sorts of Puritan belief, including Dod, Richard Sibbes, John Cotton, Robert Bolton, William Price, Peter Bulkeley, and Thomas Hooker.¹⁴⁷ As this group of associates indicates, Preston had a much more uncertain relationship with radicalism and conformity than Dod, and association with him does not necessarily indicate any radicalism on Knightley’s part, in either religious or political terms. Like Knightley and John Eliot, Preston was a client of Buckingham for the early part of the 1620s and, through his intervention, had been raised to significant political offices, including that of chaplain to Prince Charles.¹⁴⁸ Like Knightley, Preston turned away from the Caroline regime in the middle of the 1620s, although for a more typical reason than Knightley: dissatisfaction with the Spanish Match.¹⁴⁹ Nonetheless, he was an influential enough man around the court even after his break with Buckingham, that Joseph Mead could describe him as ‘a man in speciall favour with the king’.¹⁵⁰ Having been nominated for the position of Lord Keeper by Buckingham in 1625, Preston was conspicuous among Puritans in not opposing Buckingham’s appointment to the chancellorship of the University of Cambridge, although, according to Clarke, he delivered a rather subtle slight to the duke when toasting his health at his celebratory banquet, only touching the toast-glass to his lips rather than quaffing.¹⁵¹ This is a very moderate protest, perhaps indicative of Preston’s not particularly extreme nature.

In general, the social life of a Puritan clergyman followed a fairly consistent pattern from university to a provincial preaching post. This was a process by which connections made at university were then distributed across the country by the centrifugal force of parish appointment. In his seminal article on Cambridge University and ‘the country’ from 1560 to 1640, Victor Morgan showed how the links between particular colleges and certain localities in the early Stuart period served to send young men from institutions where they were exposed to a range of often highly reformed religious ideas into entirely new localities with a sharpened sense of belonging to a particular national political grouping.¹⁵² As such, when examining the networks of early modern Puritan clergy that Knightley cultivated, one should not restrict consideration to preaching, lecturing, or other expressly religious

¹⁴⁵Robert Brenner, *Merchants and Revolution* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1993), 252.

¹⁴⁶Webster, *Godly Clergy*, 13.

¹⁴⁷TNA, PROB 11/154. John Preston’s 1618 will.

¹⁴⁸Irvonwy Morgan, *Prince Charles’s Puritan Chaplain* (London: Allen & Unwin, 1957).

¹⁴⁹Thomas Ball, *The Life of the Renowned Doctor Preston*, ed. E. W. Harcourt (Oxford, 1885), 115.

¹⁵⁰British Library, Harley MS 389, fol. 428. Correspondence from Joseph Mead.

¹⁵¹Morgan, *Prince Charles’s Puritan Chaplain*, 173.

¹⁵²Victor Morgan, ‘Cambridge University and ‘The Country’, 1560–1640’, in *The University in Society, vol. I: Oxford and Cambridge from the 14th to the Early 19th Century*, ed. Lawrence Stone (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1974), 183–246.

behaviours. It is likely that there was rarely a clear distinction among the spiritual, administrative, and educational spheres. Preston's role at Cambridge enabled him to meet and influence a generation of divines before they were dispersed across the country, a network of influential Puritans, both conformist and non-conformist, into which non-university men like Knightley could then tap through Preston.

Looking at the other men who supported Preston during his life, including Fulke Greville, the first Lord Brooke, who provided him with a stipend of around £50,¹⁵³ and Lord Saye, who attended him on his deathbed, one can see that Preston provided Knightley a connection to a wider Puritan world.¹⁵⁴ John Wilkins, Dod's maternal grandson, was another protégé of Knightley's, who extended Knightley's network and allowed his influence, through Wilkins, to continue into the second half of the seventeenth century. Knightley presented Wilkins to the vicarage at Fawsley in June 1637. Wilkins was also chaplain to Viscount Saye and Sele, and Saye and Knightley were both among the parliamentary visitors who installed Wilkins as Warden of Wadham College, Oxford. Wilkins went on to marry Oliver Cromwell's sister Robina in 1656.¹⁵⁵ Knightley's preeminence among Preston's other patrons is revealed in his dedication in Preston's collection of sermons, *The Golden Scepter Held Forth to the Humble*, posthumously published in 1635 on the initiative of Thomas Ball and Thomas Goodwin. Preston's publishers note that they were 'deputed' by Preston to his most 'special friend', Knightley, whose home Preston had 'put off and la[id] up his (then) decaying and declining body.'¹⁵⁶

The efficacy of using social networks to map patterns of allegiance among early Stuart clergymen and gentry has been the subject of some debate. One example comes from Nicholas Tyacke, who has been criticised by Tom Webster for his suggestion that it was possible to recreate national patterns of allegiance from the list of signatories of one 1629 clerical petition in defence of the vicar Thomas Hooker, who had been accused of being turbulent.¹⁵⁷ The high concentration of signatures from particular counties, identified by Tyacke as an indicator of some religious quality of those areas, was seen by Webster as the probable result of sampling error, the clusters being indicative of the locations of Hooker's closest friends.¹⁵⁸ The 'national' quality of the Puritan clerical network to which I refer must therefore be qualified by an understanding of its informality and of its members' bias towards proximity. Anthony Milton has recently published a study of the religious life of the Cheshire Puritan divine Samuel Torshell, who travelled regularly between London and his locality in the years before the Civil War. Using Torshell's diary, and the list of dinners, sermons, and meetings it records, Milton aims to recreate Torshell's religious networks and

¹⁵³Barbara Donagan, 'The Clerical Patronage of Robert Rich, Second Earl of Warwick, 1619–1642', *Proceedings of the American Philosophical Society* 120, no. 5 (1976), 404.

¹⁵⁴Morgan, *Prince Charles's Puritan Chaplain*, 66.

¹⁵⁵Mary Beale, 'Wilkins, John (1614–1672)', *Oxford Dictionary of National Biography* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2004).

¹⁵⁶John Preston, *The Golden Scepter Held Forth to the Humble* (London: Printed by F. Eglesfield, 1638), 7.

¹⁵⁷Webster, *Godly Clergy in Early Stuart England*, 153.

¹⁵⁸T. W. Davids, *Annals of Evangelical Nonconformity in the County of Essex* (London: Jackson, Walford and Hodder, 1863), 153–61.

political allegiances.¹⁵⁹ Although Knightley did not leave a diary available for consultation, his role within the social and religious *milieu* of his county was well documented in the diaries of others. One of these was Thomas Dugard, a Warwickshire diarist who, by virtue of his position as a minor member of provincial quasi-clerical society and friend of prominent clerics, was a hanger-on within some of the most important Puritan social circles of the Midlands in the 1630s.

Dugard, possibly a victim of the elite over-production of the time, was a teacher at Warwick School, trapped in what was often considered a stop-gap profession for graduates; Ann Hughes describes him as an obscure pedant and bore.¹⁶⁰ His diary, in the British Library, contains valuable insight into the Puritan connections of this period. Dugard, who remained within the established church throughout all the upheavals of the 1630s, 1640s, and 1650s, was a member of the quiet, conventional faction of English moderate intellectual Puritans of the period.¹⁶¹ His experience of the politics of the early Stuart period appears somewhat to resemble Knightley's: a semi-moderate Puritan moving in more outwardly rebellious circles. The first encounter between Knightley and Dugard recorded in the diary occurs on 14 September 1633, when Dugard records having lodged at the home of a Mr Knightley in Preston Capes while in Northamptonshire.¹⁶² The manner in which this is written suggests it was a relatively unremarkable occurrence. Knightley appears to have stayed in Warwick for around a week in early September 1635, dining with Dugard on 3 and 4 September, alongside John Pym and Lord Brooke on the second occasion.¹⁶³ The occasion for Knightley's visit was likely a meeting of the Providence Island Company in Warwick around that time.¹⁶⁴ Hughes has suggested that Dugard visited Knightley in the first half of May 1637.¹⁶⁵ Dugard's diary does not appear to contain such a reference, and this may be the result of a mis-reading, in Dugard's spidery hand, of a reference to his cousin, a certain Mr Kimberley.¹⁶⁶ On 19 September 1638, Lord Brooke entertained the Earl of Bedford, Lords Digby and Russell, Knightley, and Pym to celebrate a fast day.¹⁶⁷ Pym's presence here alongside Knightley, neither of them accompanied by their wives, as Russell, Digby, and Bedford were, lends credence to the notion that Pym was living at Fawsley at the time. Like Knightley and Preston, Dugard was capable of being seduced into the royal orbit. When King Charles visited Warwick in August 1636, the difference in behaviour between Dugard and Brooke is notable: Dugard gave the oration of welcome to the king. Dugard's oration is entirely conventional and praises the king as 'crowned, yes, surrounded by all the virtues'. Brooke, pointedly, made sure not to be in Warwick at the time.¹⁶⁸ From what

¹⁵⁹Anthony Milton, 'Growing Opposition? Puritan Cheshire in Laudian London: The Diary of Samuel Torshell, 1638-9', in *Religion, Politics and the Public Sphere, 1500-1850*, eds. David Como and Michael Questier (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2025), 160-85.

¹⁶⁰Hughes, 'Thomas Dugard and his Circle', 774.

¹⁶¹Ian Green, 'Career Prospects and Clerical Conformity in the Early Stuart Church', *Past & Present* 90, no. 1 (1981), 71-115.

¹⁶²British Library, Add. MS 23146, fol. 21r, Diary of Thomas Dugard.

¹⁶³*Ibid.*, fol. 44v.

¹⁶⁴CO 124/2 fol.305, Journal of the Providence Island Company.

¹⁶⁵Hughes, 'Thomas Dugard and his Circle', 781, n. 60, citing British Library, Add. MS 23146, fol. 64v.

¹⁶⁶British Library, Add. MS 23146, fol. 64v, Diary of Thomas Dugard.

¹⁶⁷*Ibid.*, fol. 79r.

¹⁶⁸Hughes, 'Thomas Dugard and his Circle', 788.

is known of Knightley, his reaction to a full royal visit might have resembled either of the two men's responses. In general, the religious 'radicalism' of the Northamptonshire divine group which Knightley associated with was relatively latent during the Personal Rule, before being reactivated by the national petitioning campaign against the Canons of 1640.

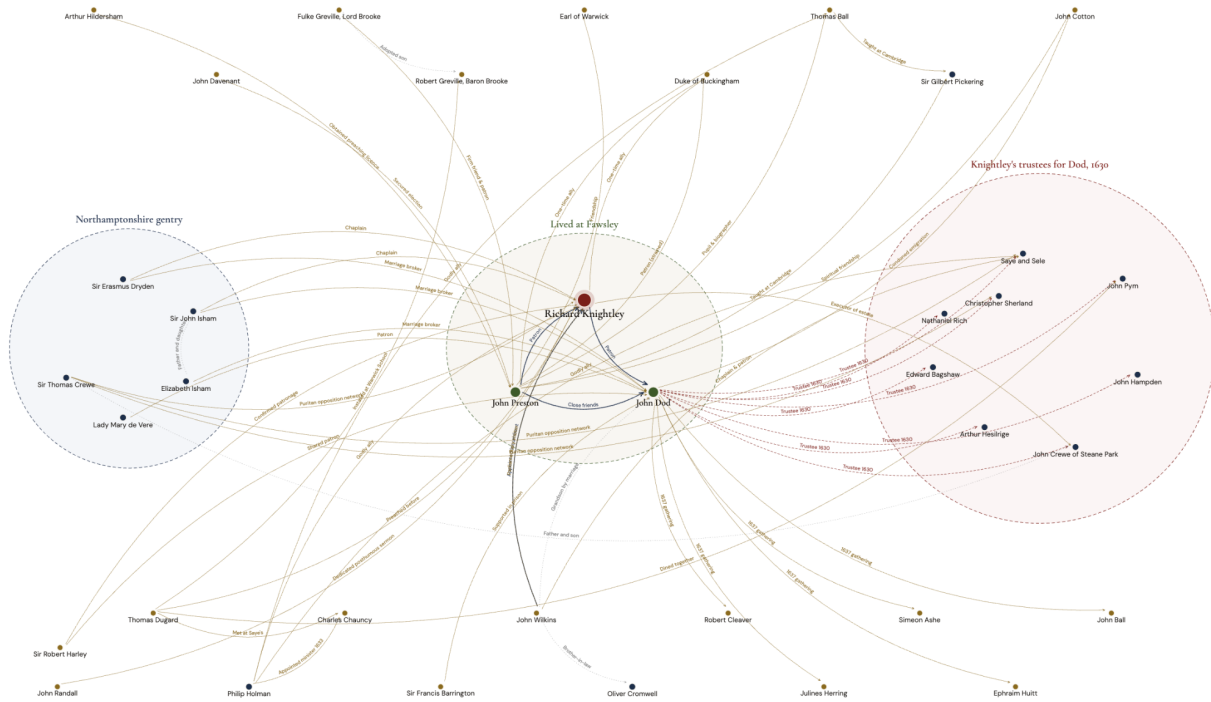


Figure 2.1: A network diagram of relationships among Knightley, Preston, and Dod mentioned in this dissertation.

In the absence of much accessible evidence of Knightley's precise religious views, this chapter has attempted to throw some light on his religious placement by examining his network of association within Northamptonshire, a county with a very diverse Puritan contingent. Knightley's position within that community was not fixed, and his great contribution was his convening influence at Fawsley. Thomas Ball's contemporary description of the sermon Dod delivered at Preston's funeral in Northamptonshire, despite the two priests being different kinds of Puritan altogether, perhaps best captures the religious atmosphere Knightley created at Fawsley, with Ball writing that 'a world of Godly people came together' for the funeral.¹⁶⁹ Knightley's religious world, shaped over a long period in part by his association with Dod and other priests, appears to have been a far more diverse, moderate, and inclusive one than has been suggested in much of the historiography concerning him.

¹⁶⁹Ball, *Life of Preston*, 175.

Chapter 3: Enterprise and Colonial Companies

Another way to assess Knightley's connection to the core of organised Puritan activity during the Personal Rule is to examine his relationship with the leadership of various Puritan-dominated New World colonial companies. By doing so, this dissertation will also seek to engage with a long-standing historiographical debate about the specific purpose of these colonial companies by analysing Knightley's company memberships and investments with his political and religious associations in mind. Knightley was a member of at least four Puritan colonial companies, and as such, is a particularly profitable object of study. These were the Virginia Company, the Somers Islands Company, the Providence Island Company, and the Saybrook Colony, a venture to found a Puritan settlement in Connecticut. A significant number of Knightley's religious and political associates were also involved with colonial enterprises. One need only examine the list of trustees Knightley named to John Dod's trust in 1630 to identify various eminent colonial investors, including John Pym and Nathaniel Rich. Robert Brenner points to two of Knightley's close associates, the Earl of Warwick and Nathaniel Rich, as particularly important members of the 'powerful East Anglian Puritan gentry connection'.¹⁷⁰ These two men, who were central figures in Knightley's religious world, were also among the most prolific investors in and administrators of Puritan New World settlement companies. Focusing on Knightley's role as a founding member of the Providence Island Company, an enterprise to establish a godly colony off the Mosquito Coast, in which Knightley invested and whose meetings he hosted at his home, this chapter will challenge the contention that Knightley's political beliefs can be reconstructed with reference to his commercial interests. Providence Island is a well-studied example of a legitimately Puritan settlement established with specific colonial interests in mind. The company failed to establish the religious settlement it desired and instead collapsed into privateering.¹⁷¹

Knightley lived decades before the advent of printed, nationally distributed stock price lists, a development that Larry Neal identified as a key factor in the rise of formal capital markets.¹⁷² Thus, he lived in a time before financial relationships and investment became depersonalised, and it would be a mistake to analyse Knightley's commercial interests through the austere lens of profit and loss. Investment in these colonial companies was necessarily personal and often tied up in Puritan religious and personal identities. This was especially true of enterprises dedicated to creating godly settlements in the New World. The divines whom Knightley supported had some interaction with the commercial world of New World colonisation. Dod and his circle played a significant role in shaping the religious world of the burgeoning Massachusetts colony, and Dod counselled those who had doubts about the ethics of emigrating and leaving their co-religionists in England behind. When John Cotton wrote from New England in 1634 to explain why he had emigrated with Thomas Hooker, he noted that Dod had advised him that the scriptural account of St Peter's flight from

¹⁷⁰Brenner, *Merchants and Revolution*, 252.

¹⁷¹Karen Ordahl Kupperman, *Providence Island, 1630–1641: The Other Puritan Colony* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1993), 210.

¹⁷²Larry Neal, *The Rise of Financial Capitalism: International Capital Markets in the Age of Reason* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1990), 21.

persecution offered him a religious justification for escaping England.¹⁷³ Knightley's spiritual and commercial lives were intertwined.

It is not surprising that historians interested in seeing the Civil War from a longer perspective have regularly looked to draw links between the various Puritan colonial enterprises of the decade and a half before 1640 and the political groupings, particularly the 'middle group', in both houses of parliament in the 1640s. There has been a significant historiographical association between the Puritan colonising companies and Puritan extra-parliamentary political organisation during the Personal Rule. A. P. Newton's 1914 book *The Colonising Activities of the English Puritans* played a significant role in shaping the historiographical field. In this book, Newton influentially argued that colonial companies operated, in essence, as umbrella organisations for the management of political Puritan campaigns in the absence of parliament.¹⁷⁴ Robert Ashton made an even more sweeping assertion in his 1978 book on the origins of the Civil War, which was that almost the entirety of the London merchant elite, aggrieved by the mounting burden of extra-parliamentary taxation, was swept up in the political opposition to the crown in the 1630s.¹⁷⁵ This more extreme claim has not been received into the historiographical mainstream and does not appear to cohere with evidence about the activities of mainstream colonial companies like the East India Company, whose directorate remained broadly cooperative with crown during the 1630s and did not offer any open support to the parliamentary cause from 1640–1641.¹⁷⁶

Newton's claim about the nature of Puritan companies has had more staying power than Ashton's. Robert Brenner, a Marxist historian drawn to the economic explanation of political change, suggests that the group of Puritan colonial entrepreneurs who provided the capital and leadership necessary for these highly speculative settlements in the New World, whom he labels the 'new merchants', were significantly more politically rebellious than the merchant mainstream during the Personal Rule. Though Brenner suggests that the growth of 'new merchant' companies was associated with the emboldening of the gentry and middling sort,¹⁷⁷ something which accords with the class-hypothesis of the English Civil War posed by historians including Lawrence Stone, it cannot be overlooked that some nobles including the Earl of Warwick, the Earl of Holland, and Lord Saye and Sele were significant investors in these New World colonial companies. Historians have also challenged the belief that individuals holding company membership in common is evidence enough to suggest that certain positive political objectives were shared. As early as the 1970s, Christopher Thompson challenged the idea that the Providence Island Company and the New England Company were 'simple surrogates' for the parliamentary opposition during the Personal Rule, arguing as such in a paper delivered in a Cambridge University early modern history seminar that was subsequently

¹⁷³A. Young, ed., *Chronicles of the First Planters of the Colony of Massachusetts Bay 1623–1636* (Boston, MA, 1846), 438–44.

¹⁷⁴A. P. Newton, *The Colonising Activities of the English Puritans: The Last Phase of the Elizabethan Struggle with Spain* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1914).

¹⁷⁵Robert Ashton, *The English Civil War: Conservatism and Revolution, 1603–1649* (London: Weidenfeld and Nicolson, 1978), 204.

¹⁷⁶Brenner, *Merchants and Revolution*, 291.

¹⁷⁷*Ibid.*, 251.

published in the 1980s.¹⁷⁸ Studies of specific colonial enterprises, particularly Karen Ordahl Kupperman's study of Providence Island, have departed from Newton's argument by highlighting the relative political diversity and commercial basis of these companies.

To assess the relative connectivity of individuals across the six Puritan colonial companies, I have compiled a dataset of their patentees, members, and subscribers. There is a degree of methodological difficulty posed by a focus on Puritan companies. Nothing of the scale of the East India Company archives exists for the other English companies in this period, and the fragmentary nature of records makes it difficult to compile a complete list of subscribers for many seventeenth-century colonial enterprises. Many individuals gained membership of companies by transferring shares, a process that does not always lend itself to easy record-keeping. For instance, Noel Malcolm discovered that Thomas Hobbes gained membership of the Virginia Company through a share gifted by his employer, Lord Cavendish.¹⁷⁹ Many similar transfers of company subscriptions likely occurred and went unrecorded. Given these methodological problems, these data can be regarded as somewhat incomplete, allowing only a rough outline of the shared patronage of these subscribers across various enterprises to be drawn. To collate this dataset, I have relied on various lists of company members in a mixture of printed and manuscript sources. Individuals were categorised as members or subscribers either when they were positively identified as such in company records or when they were present at a company council. Categories of membership and their associated costs varied significantly from company to company, so these data can be taken to indicate the association between individuals and companies more accurately than they represent any actual financial interests.

Karen Ordahl Kupperman has prepared a list of members of the Providence Island Company.¹⁸⁰ I have collated the names of individual investors in printed records of the Virginia,¹⁸¹ Massachusetts Bay,¹⁸² and New England companies.¹⁸³ The Ferrar Papers in Magdalene College, Cambridge, provide additional records of the names of subscribers and members of the Virginia and Somers Islands Companies, in the form of correspondence and notes made by Nicholas Ferrar.¹⁸⁴ Printed lists of patentees of both the Virginia and Somers Island Companies also exist.¹⁸⁵ A list of patentees for the Saybrook Colony is provided in the company's 1632 patent,¹⁸⁶ and lists of members are also

¹⁷⁸Christopher Thompson, *Two Puritan Commonwealths: Providence and New England* (Wivenhoe: Orchard, 1987), 1.

¹⁷⁹Noel Malcolm, 'Hobbes, Sandys, and the Virginia Company', *Historical Journal* 24, no. 2 (1981), 297–321.

¹⁸⁰Kupperman, *Providence Island*, 357–60.

¹⁸¹Susan Myra Kingsbury, ed., *The Records of the Virginia Company of London*, (Washington, DC: Library of Congress, 1906–35).

¹⁸²Nathaniel B. Shurtleff, ed., *Records of the Governor and Company of the Massachusetts Bay in New England* (Boston: W. White, 1854).

¹⁸³Charles Deane, ed., *Records of the Council for New England* (Cambridge, MA: Press of John Wilson & Son, 1867); Francis Newton Thorpe, ed., 'The Charter of New England: 1620', in *The Federal and State Constitutions, Colonial Charters, and Other Organic Laws of the States, Territories, and Colonies Now or Heretofore Forming the United States of America* (Washington, DC: Government Printing Office, 1909).

¹⁸⁴Magdalene College, Cambridge, Ferrar Papers, FR 482, 'The names of people admitted to shares in Virginia'; FR 473, 'A copie of ye acte of counsell touchinge the Virginia and Summer islands companies concerninge the contracte and the tres'. With thanks to the Master and Fellows of Magdalene College.

¹⁸⁵John Henry Lefroy, *Memorials of the Discovery and Early Settlement of the Bermudas or Somers Islands, 1515–1685*, 1 (Bermuda: The Bermuda Historical Society and The Bermuda National Trust, 1981).

¹⁸⁶C. J. Hoadly, *The Warwick Patent* (Hartford: Case, Lockwood & Brainard, 1902).

available in printed editions of the venture's records.¹⁸⁷ In identifying individuals from the sets of records cited above, I intended to tease out relationships that might have had political significance or otherwise been strengthened by shared membership of the same company. Using these data, a rudimentary quantitative network analysis can be conducted. In sociology, John F. Padgett and Christopher K. Ansell's enormously influential paper 'Robust Action and the Rise of the Medici, 1400–1434', provides a basis for the study of individual connections, by nature and volume, as a means to establish centres of influence and power.¹⁸⁸ The authors of this paper, who built a database of Florentine personal relationships totalling tens of thousands, stress that social influence emerged from the interplay of multiple overlapping social networks, rather than deliberate strategic placement. Although my data on company membership are more modest than those used by Padgett and Ansell, this prosopographical approach suits the study of Knightley, who appears to have been a figure who united several other politico-cultural groups.

Using the variable k to denote each adventurer's affiliation degree, which is the number of companies they were affiliated with, one can assess which individuals had the greatest breadth of affiliation within this dataset. Filtering by $k \geq n$, with increasing values of the threshold n , reveals a core group of repeat company members. Sir Nathaniel Rich ($k = 6$) and his cousin, the Earl of Warwick ($k = 6$), have the greatest number of company memberships. They are followed by Richard Knightley ($k = 4$). Among the 771 individuals in this dataset, there is a small group of 15 whose positioning can be described by $k \geq 3$. Many of these individuals, including John Humfrey and Sir Richard Saltonstall, are known for their leadership within colonial enterprises. Although some of them, like the 'fierce Presbyterian' Sir Gilbert Gerard,¹⁸⁹ belonged to the most politically radical section of early Stuart society, this is a religiously and politically heterogeneous group. As well as royalists such as Holland, a significant number of the group - Sir Nathaniel Rich, Sir Dudley Digges, and John Pym - had been members of a faction that had attempted to safeguard parliament's future in the 1620s by providing the king with a larger income, a moderate solution.¹⁹⁰

¹⁸⁷Hugh R. Engstrom, 'Sir Arthur Hesilrige and the Saybrook Colony', *Albion* 5, no. 3 (1973).

¹⁸⁸John F. Padgett and Christopher K. Ansell, 'Robust Action and the Rise of the Medici, 1400–1434', *American Journal of Sociology* 98, no. 6 (1993), 1259–319.

¹⁸⁹M. W. Helms, 'Gerard, Sir Gilbert, 1st Bt. (1587–1670)', in *The History of Parliament: The House of Commons 1660–1690*, ed. B. D. Henning (London: Secker & Warburg, 1983).

¹⁹⁰*Memoirs of Sir Benjamin Rudyerd*, ed. J. A. Manning (London: 1841), 80.

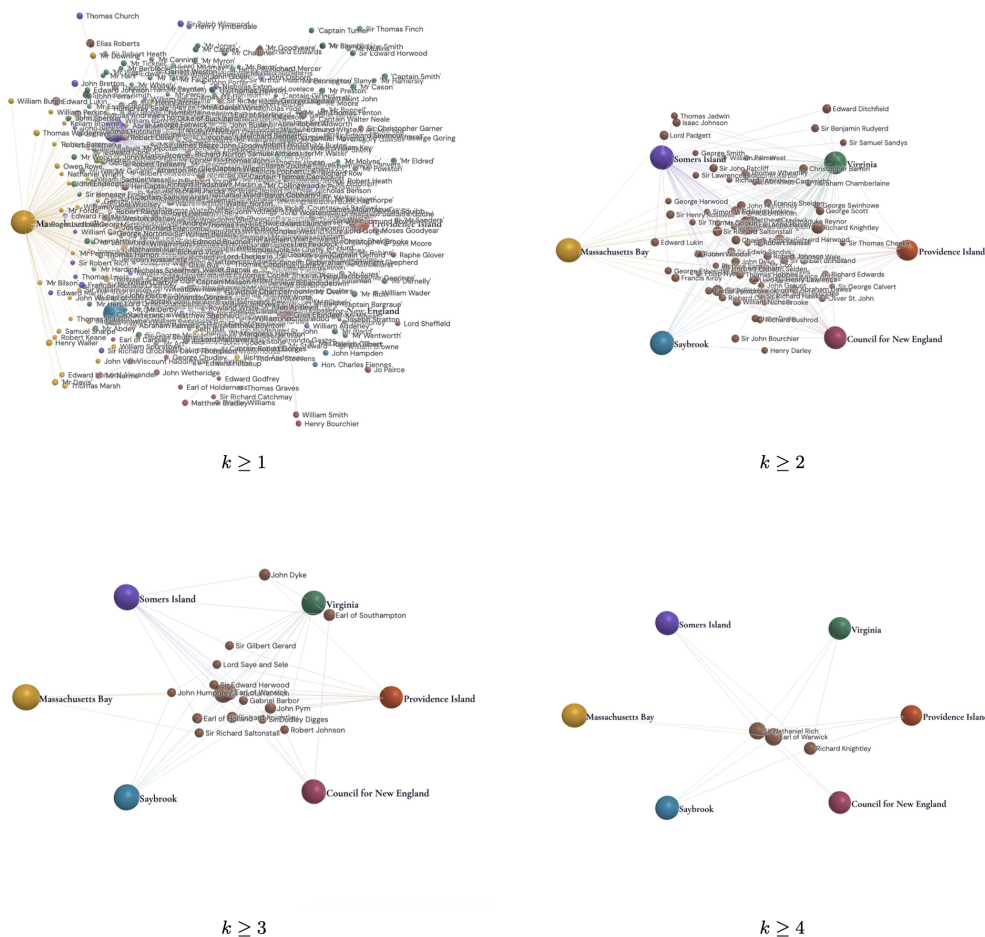


Figure 3.1: An undirected network graph of membership of six colonial companies using data collected for this dissertation.

Although it has been suggested that the extent of speculative investment undertaken by individuals in England was legally limited until the advent of limited liability legislation in the nineteenth century, this view has been significantly challenged by historians from the 1980s onwards.¹⁹¹ The number of companies to which Knightley provided capital, and indeed the number of individual company members noted in this chapter who provided capital to a diverse range of joint-stock companies, appears to pose a further challenge to the notion that the absence of limited liability was a serious constraint on investors. William Holdsworth explains in his *History of the English Law* that, ‘as early as the fifteenth century it was clear that an individual corporator was not personally liable for the debts of the corporation and after some hesitation this conclusion was ultimately accepted in the latter part of the sixteenth century [in the common law courts]’.¹⁹² However, while investment behaviour like this was not necessarily financially risky and might have been beneficial to generating a profit, it was not widespread. Research on the behaviour of joint-stock investors in the

¹⁹¹Gary M. Anderson and Robert D. Tollison, ‘The Myth of the Corporation as a Creation of the State’, *International Review of Law and Economics* 3, 2 (1983), 110.

¹⁹²William Holdsworth, *A History of English Law*, 8 (London: Methuen, 1966), 221.

later part of the seventeenth century and into the eighteenth century suggests that the practice of individuals hedging their exposure to idiosyncratic risk by engaging in cross-ownership across their equity portfolios only emerged in the eighteenth century.¹⁹³ Investment manuals outlining methods to calculate simple and compound interest, rates of return and the size of corporate dividends only started to appear at all in the second decade of the eighteenth century, with early examples like Richard Hayes's *The Money'd Man's Guide* only appearing in print a full century after the formation of many of the Puritan colonial companies discussed here.¹⁹⁴ There is little evidence that the buyers of equity in early Stuart colonial companies knew of the benefits of portfolio diversification.

Analysis by Ann Carlos, Erin Fletcher, and Larry Neal reveals low levels of diversification in share portfolios among individual investors in the latter part of the seventeenth century. Their data suggest that around 80% of stockholders between 1690 and 1710 held equity in only one company.¹⁹⁵ This was the case despite an enormous boom in the number of individual investors in the second half of the seventeenth century as the market for shares and securities swelled.¹⁹⁶ It appears that the situation was broadly similar in the first half of the seventeenth century. Of the 771 discrete individual company members I identified from the records of the six New World colonial companies, around 83% (638 individuals) were members of only one company. The limited selection of joint-stock companies will almost certainly have distorted these data, and the exclusion from this dataset of relatively high-subscription mercantile enterprises outside of the New World, including the East India Company and the Levant Company, likely inflated the number of single-company individuals. Knightley was one of the few individuals I have identified who was a member of three or more companies. As noted, this group accounts for around 2% of the total selection (15 individuals). Aside from the lack of good financial information and theory available to investors, another possible explanation for why individuals were so rarely members of more than one company is that, in this early era of joint-stock companies, when shareholders administered the day-to-day operations of companies, share ownership carried significant governance responsibilities that were not easily juggled. Moreover, the distribution of voting rights within these companies, including the specific Puritan companies under consideration in this chapter, favoured individuals with higher levels of equity ownership.¹⁹⁷ As such, it does not appear that there were many widely known financial or governance benefits to diluting one's investments across multiple memberships. This was especially true for men like Knightley, who did not appear to have much personal involvement in the administration of these companies, either in England or the New World.

One convincing explanation for this small and generally very socially elite group having cross-membership of multiple colonial companies is the social value of membership and the associative

¹⁹³ Ann M. Carlos, Erin Fletcher, and Larry Neal, 'Share Portfolios in the Early Years of Financial Capitalism: London, 1690–1730', *Economic History Review* 68, no. 2 (2015), 574–99.

¹⁹⁴ Richard Hayes, *The Money'd Man's Guide* (London: printed for W. Meadows, 1726).

¹⁹⁵ Carlos, Fletcher, and Neal, 'Share Portfolios', 575.

¹⁹⁶ Anne Murphy, *The Origins of English Financial Markets: Investment and Speculation Before the South Sea Bubble* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2013).

¹⁹⁷ Ann M. Carlos, 'Bonding and the Agency Problem: Evidence from the Royal African Company, 1672–1691', *Explorations in Economic History* 31, no. 3 (1994), 313–35.

value of holding membership in multiple companies. There has been historiographical discussion of the influence of burgeoning joint-stock companies on the style of personal association in early Stuart England. Some have suggested that the emergence of merchant companies of this sort (along with the increasingly influential growth of livery companies and guilds) led to networks of voluntary association and the evolution of associational life, becoming media through which individuals could define their commitments and associations publicly. Phil Withington has suggested as much, claiming that these Puritan colonial companies played a part in the development of a public sphere among the elite of London society during the seventeenth century.¹⁹⁸ In her recent work, Rupali Mishra has similarly emphasised how colonial joint-stock companies engaged, consciously or not, in a process of ‘widening the nation’ and diversifying the forms of political and social expression available to individuals in early modern England.¹⁹⁹ Colonial companies, which had swelled in size and administrative complexity throughout the 1620s and 1630s, had come to occupy positions of fairly significant importance in the public sphere. Mishra has placed particular emphasis on the differences between the political experiences of more senior members (company leaders, their secretaries, and officeholders) and the wider general membership of colonial companies. Given Knightley’s connections and centrality to the organisation of some companies, Knightley can be considered a leading member of at least one colonial enterprise and was perhaps part of one of the in-groups that Mishra describes. In a society that was increasingly interested in the value of formal associations and groups, as Peter Clark has demonstrated of seventeenth-century England,²⁰⁰ company membership might have been a valuable signal of belonging to a certain in-group. Although not necessarily political, this was important to this group of men who would otherwise have felt somewhat disparate, were unable to attend parliament, did not identify with the direction of travel of the established church and were not members of the most influential guilds and corporations of the time. It supports this thesis that the religious objectives of the Providence Island Company appear similar to those of many other Puritan companies mentioned. Although the degree of ambition of Providence Island adventurers to actually emigrate was much lower than in other ventures, with none of the Providence Island members apparently interested in emigrating compared to most of the members of the Saybrook colony, these men were clearly interested in supporting the settlement of those escaping Laudian control of the church.

It accords with this suggestion about the social element of company membership that Knightley’s association with colonial activity was remarkably personal and was passed down through Puritan patriarchal lines. Knightley, who was only five years old upon the death of his father Edward Knightley, had been the ward of his father’s ‘true and faithful friend’ Sir Thomas Smythe while

¹⁹⁸Phil Withington, ‘Public Discourse, Corporate Citizenship, and State Formation in Early Modern England’, *American Historical Review* 112, no. 4 (2007), 1016–38.

¹⁹⁹Rupali Mishra, ‘In the Company of Merchants: Edward Sherburne, the East India Company, and the Transformation of Stuart Political Practices’, in *Political and Religious Practice in the Early Modern British World*, ed. William J. Bulman and Freddy C. Domínguez (Manchester: Manchester University Press, 2026), 77–96.

²⁰⁰Peter Clark, *British Clubs and Societies, 1580–1800: The Origins of an Associational World* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 2000).

growing up.²⁰¹ Smythe, who was the governor of the Virginia Company, likely influenced Knightley's entrepreneurial activity. Knightley would eventually invest in the Virginia Company as well as the closely associated Somers Islands Company. Knightley appears to have become a member of the Virginia Company at some point before October 1622, when, as Magdalene College's Ferrar Papers indicate, he was added to the company's Committee for Petitions.²⁰² He does not appear to have been a particularly active investor, however, and in May 1623, Knightley was included in a list of the names of 'adventurers and free of the Virginia Company' that 'haue not had any parte nor followde the buissiness for sundry yeares.'²⁰³ This appears to have been a pattern in Knightley's commercial undertakings, where he was usually not very involved in the management of companies. Thus, it is valuable to approach Knightley's investing behaviour in a prosopographical manner, although one must make sure not to define Knightley's beliefs solely with regard to those proximal to him.

Brenner suggests that the supposed socio-economic contrast between 'company' merchants and this class of 'new merchants' can be mapped onto their political allegiances. The dominant elite of merchants associated with the East India and Levant Companies, dependent on the chartered privileges granted by the Crown to avoid competition, rarely opposed the king. In Brenner's Marxist terms, a 'politico-jurisdictional element of the [monarchy] had long been transcended in the property of the landlord class... [and] was a crucial determinant of their perspective on politics'.²⁰⁴ In contrast to their more established competitors, these 'new merchants', whose business was less entwined with royal patronage, were freer to turn away from the king. Because the period under consideration predates the 1720 Bubble Act, which imposed penalties on the operation of any unchartered enterprise and is generally thought to have delayed English business development and restricted the supply of investment capital, it was possible for the Puritan enterprises under consideration to operate independently of the government. Brenner explains the involvement of noblemen in colonising enterprises as the result of the temporary convergence of interests between an 'aristocratic colonising opposition' and the 'new merchant' grouping, with the Puritan noblemen interested in ventures including the Bermuda and Providence Island Companies principally because, alongside the prospect of Puritan settlement, they offered freedom from royal influence and an outlet for anti-Spanish foreign policy. Brenner, who suggested that most of these new colonial enterprises were reliant upon the involvement of the middling sort, has argued that the ability of the Providence Island Company and the Somers Island Company to function effectively on the basis of gentry and noble finance was principally the result of the 'exceptional' factor of Puritan involvement with the companies.²⁰⁵ Drawing on Newton, Brenner suggests that these companies were 'outposts of Puritanism, at once ports of exile and staging posts for revolt'. To substantiate his claim about the political bent of these companies, Brenner points to the activities of company men outside a corporate context, like John Hampden and Oliver St John's (both members of the

²⁰¹TNA, PROB 11/92, fol. 317v, Edward Knightley's 1615 will.

²⁰²Magdalene College, Cambridge, FR 482, 'The names of people admitted to shares in Virginia, 1623'.

²⁰³Kingsbury, *Records of the Virginia Company*, IV, 157.

²⁰⁴Brenner, *Merchants and Revolution*, 670.

²⁰⁵*Ibid.*, 110.

Providence Island Company) role in the 1637 Ship Money case.²⁰⁶

Brenner and Newton's suggestion about the politics of these groups does not entirely accord with what is known of the activities of some of their principal members. Sir Nathaniel Rich and the Earl of Warwick, for example, were repeat colonial administrators whose interests appear to have lain in establishing successful overseas colonies. Both Warwick and Rich were among the most experienced colonists of the period and, as W. F. Craven has laid out, were both enormously skilled at generating profit from overseas businesses.²⁰⁷ Indeed, the dissolution of the Virginia Company in 1624 had been largely due to Warwick's efforts to protect his substantial private interests in the associated colony of Bermuda.²⁰⁸ More widely, Brenner's suggestion that commercial overseas companies' attempts to avoid duties imposed by the crown during the Personal Rule constituted political actions, describing attempts to avoid tax as a 'general strike against nonparliamentary taxation on trade',²⁰⁹ appears vulnerable to the same criticism that Morrill and other revisionist historians subjected political interpretations of Ship Money disputes to. Correspondence between the English company leaders of Providence Island and the leadership of the colony off the Mosquito Coast, which took an ever more frantic tone as the colony's fortunes declined, provides an indication of just how important returns were to the company's management in England. In one letter of 1634 to his colonial agent, Warwick explicitly stated that he was looking for the deployment of slaves in the colony 'with regard to my profit.'²¹⁰ The use of slavery, although not the subject of significant Puritan political opposition at the time, indicates Warwick's determination to maximise the colony's returns by minimising labour costs.

The Rich family were involved in all the colonial enterprises that Knightley was a member of, with the colonising section of the family consisting of Warwick, Nathaniel Rich, and Warwick's brother, the Earl of Holland. What is notable is that, despite all being Puritans, these three did not have similar politics. Warwick was a parliamentarian, Nathaniel Rich had advocated a strategy of appeasement towards Charles in the 1620s, and Holland had been a close associate of Buckingham and would become a royalist who was eventually executed by the parliamentary regime in 1649.²¹¹ Although he was rarely involved in the day-to-day operation of the Company and, according to William Jessop's final reckoning of investors' debts, held his membership without ever having invested any money,²¹² Holland's support of the Providence Island Company appears to complicate the thesis that this was an operation with a clearly political and anti-government purpose. Newton does not go much further than Holland's anti-Spanish foreign policy in explaining the character of Holland's participation in the company.²¹³ Karen Ordahl Kupperman, attempting to categorise the

²⁰⁶Ibid., 292.

²⁰⁷W. F. Craven, 'The Earl of Warwick, Speculator in Privateering', *Hispanic American Historical Review* 10 (1930), 457–79.

²⁰⁸Thompson, *Two Puritan Commonwealths*, 10.

²⁰⁹Brenner, *Merchants and Revolution*, 240.

²¹⁰Jessop Letterbook, BL Add. MS 10615, no. 8, fol. 50, Letter from the Earl of Warwick to Hugh Wentworth.

²¹¹R. Malcolm Smuts, 'Rich, Henry, first earl of Holland (bap. 1590, d. 1649)', *Oxford Dictionary of National Biography* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2004).

²¹²Kupperman, *Providence Island*, appendix III.

²¹³Newton, *The Colonising Activities of the English Puritans*, 207.

religious affiliation of the Providence Island set, suggests that while ‘Saye, Brooke, St. John, Darley, Knightley(?) favoured the independents, Warwick, Manchester, Gerard, and Gurdon were associated with the Presbyterians, though Warwick also kept up his ties with many Independents.’²¹⁴ Kupperman’s own question mark is telling, reiterating the point that Knightley’s specific religious-political opinions are mostly obscure to historians. This also indicates that simple religio-political placement was not the only factor determining participation in this particular colonial endeavour. This comes as something of a rebuke to Newton.

Perhaps it is possible that Holland, important enough to the company that a fort on Providence Island was named ‘Fort Henry’ in his honour,²¹⁵ could have been entirely unaware of a secret political purpose the company might have had, and was deceived by his more politically minded relatives. However, Holland’s membership of other colonial companies, including the Virginia and Somers Island Companies, appears to undermine the suggestion that he was a dupe. As has been previously noted, Holland deployed his court influence in the service of the Providence Island Company. This included helping the Company obtain a charter, and also involved writing to the attorney general John Bankes to secure permission for Pym to live in London from 1636 onwards to deal with the company’s incoming shipments.²¹⁶ As the journal of the Providence Island Company reveals, Pym regularly travelled between London, Warwick, and Northamptonshire, apparently to tend to the company’s interests. Holland and Pym were of totally opposite political persuasions, and Pym’s politics were clear. It makes little sense that they would cooperate on this venture for any reason other than business.

The journal of the Providence Island Company, prepared by its secretary William Jessop and held in the National Archives, indicates that, although Knightley was an original member and contributor to the company’s foundation, who eventually owned 4.33% of the company’s debt on settlement,²¹⁷ he did not play a central role in its decision-making. He is rarely recorded contributing to meetings and did not hold a company office. In the first few years of the company’s operations, meetings were overwhelmingly held at one of two locations: ‘Brooke House’ or Warwick Castle. Both belonged to Lord Brooke. Brooke House likely refers to Lord Brooke’s London residence.²¹⁸ In the last half of the 1630s, and towards the end of Knightley’s short life, meetings began to be held in Knightley’s home more regularly. This appears to corroborate Conrad Russell’s claim that Pym, one of the company’s leading members, was living with Knightley during this period. Despite his support for Pym, Knightley’s relatively peripheral position within the company is revealed by his increasing absence from meetings. Indeed, from the middle of the decade onwards, the number of attendees at meetings dwindles down to a central group. On 24 July 1637, a committee was held at ‘Fawzily’ attended by Saye, Brooke, Viscount Mandeville (later earl of Manchester), and Pym. Knightley was not in attendance, despite it taking place at his home. This appears to lend credence

²¹⁴Kupperman, *Providence Island*, 222.

²¹⁵Kupperman, *Providence Island*, 194.

²¹⁶MS Bankes 65/1, fol. 16, Letter from the Earl of Holland to Bankes.

²¹⁷Kupperman, *Providence Island*, appendix III.

²¹⁸W. A. Eden, Marie P. G. Draper, W. F. Grimes, and Audrey Williams, ‘Conclusion’, in *Survey of London: Volume 28, Brooke House, Hackney* (London: London County Council, 1960).

not only to the notion that Knightley was not particularly involved in the company's operations but also to the idea that he allowed Pym to live there freely during this period.²¹⁹ On 29 March 1639, a court was held in 'Fawsley in the county of Northamptonshire'. Pym, the Earl of Warwick, Brooke, Mandeville, and Knightley were present.²²⁰ This was the last meeting of the Providence Island Company that Knightley attended before his death in November of the same year. He did not contribute. Overall, Jessop's journal gives little indication that any topics other than company matters were under consideration during company meetings. However, when discussing meetings of the company at Fawsley in the second half of the 1630s, Newton states with little evidential basis that 'there is no doubt that the Providence Company's affairs would demand very little share of the conversation, but the one absorbing topic would be the... best means of compelling the government to take up a definite challenge to [Ship Money].'²²¹ Although evidence from the diary of Thomas Dugard, who was identified in the previous chapter as having met Knightley around the time of a meeting of the company, suggests that meetings in the country might have involved broader social events in which non-company guests took part,²²² one can only speculate about the content of these discussions.

One possible problem with historical treatments of Puritan colonial companies is that historians, when casting back for explanations of these individuals' support of the parliamentary cause in the 1640s, have sometimes attributed inordinate importance to these companies. While it does appear that the New World companies of the 1630s had a core membership that was almost entirely Puritan, including many who harboured oppositional views of the Caroline government among their company leadership, and their meetings might have served a convening purpose for opponents of the regime, it would be too great a leap to suggest that Knightley's participation in these enterprises is evidence of political involvement. Although Knightley belonged to an unusually small group of men who were members of many Puritan colonial companies, it was still diverse enough to include outright royalists like Holland and men with moderate constitutional positions like Digges and Rich.

²¹⁹TNA, CO 124/2, fol. 305, Journal of the Providence Island Company.

²²⁰Ibid., fol. 355.

²²¹Newton, *The Colonising Activities of the English Puritans*, 242.

²²²British Library, Add. MS 23146, fol. 44v, Diary of Thomas Dugard.

Conclusion

Jorge Luis Borges's essay 'The Analytical Language of John Wilkins', a discussion of the proposal for a universal language by one of Knightley's ministers at Fawsley, artfully raises the inherent problems presented by classification schemes. Borges's contention that every attempt to classify the universe descends to the level of the 'arbitrary and conjectural' has relevance when talking about Knightley's religious life, and the politics of the Personal Rule more generally.²²³ Just as Borges notes that the word *salmon* tells us nothing about the object it represents, the labels of *conformist* and *non-conformist* can often do an inadequate job of representing an individual Puritan's beliefs. This is not to say that attempts at categorisation tell us absolutely nothing (one cannot entertain the suggestion that Knightley was 'a scaly river fish with reddish flesh'), but instead to suggest that the desire to place things in categories can obscure the fundamental nature of the thing one is attempting to describe. This is particularly true when discussing Knightley's religious and political life, in which the categories into which one feels the urge to place him did not become applicable until after his death.

There is no coherent first-hand statement of Knightley's religious or political beliefs during the Personal Rule. Most of what can be said about Knightley's politics must be pieced together second-hand, either from other (often Laudian and hostile) accounts of his life or from analysis of his associates and their views. Knightley did not live to see the historical moment in which most men of his standing found themselves compelled to declare their politics and thus assign a classification to themselves. This was the 1640s, when parliament was reconstituted, the Root and Branch petition was presented, and individuals were presented with the choice of joining the Civil War on either side. Had Knightley survived the 1630s, he might well have become a member of the parliaments of the 1640s. This is a reasonable suggestion on the basis that he had previously been an MP and was aggrieved to have lost that position in the mid-1620s. There is, however, little evidence upon which to base any claim about which side of the Civil War he would have taken. Although he was an influential Puritan, an associate of Pym and a member of the 'Bedford-Western gentry connection', it appears that many of his networks might not have been as politically polarised as has been suggested. This accords with the direction that the historiography of Puritan political culture in the past few decades has taken - away from the idea that Puritanism was a radical movement in and of itself.

A similar case can be made about Knightley's involvement in colonial enterprises: he was a relatively inactive member of multiple New World colonising companies during the 1620s and 1630s. Although the membership of some of these colonial companies was religiously aligned, with the Providence Island Company dominated by Puritans, they were neither as religiously uniform nor as engaged in political organisation as some studies have suggested. Indeed, they were home to a fairly religiously diverse collection of Puritan men. It is unclear why Knightley was so unusually widely invested in colonial companies. Several motives are possible: an interest in safeguarding any return

²²³ Jorge Luis Borges, 'The Analytical Language of John Wilkins', in *Other Inquisitions, 1937-1952*, trans. Ruth L. C. Simms (Austin: University of Texas Press, 1964), 101-05.

on investment, in the process of colonising itself, or in replicating Puritan social circles without the organising framework of parliament. Knightley was not heavily involved in the operations of any of these companies, and appears to have had more influence as a convenor, providing his home (likely John Pym's residence at the time) as a location for the Providence Island Company to host its meetings.

To assign a political label to Knightley despite these ambiguities would only further confuse the picture, or even misdirect historical thinking about Knightley. Knightley's associations cannot be considered very profitably through the lens of various Civil War-era political affiliations, because he never lived to encounter the political conditions in which his colleagues developed their, sometimes quite unexpected, views on the conflict. This dissertation has touched on the various geographic, social, political, and commercial spheres within which a godly member of the early Stuart gentry could operate. Patrick Collinson influentially described early Stuart England as consisting of a 'series of overlapping, superimposed communities which were also semi-autonomous, self-governing political cultures'.²²⁴ As has been demonstrated, Knightley's behaviour varied as he moved between social contexts, but was not as conspiratorial as some historians have suggested. Knightley had multiple loci for political expression, and this dissertation has examined his role as a local officeholder, as a patron of diverse members of the Puritan clergy, and as a member of multiple commercial companies. In all instances, these worlds have appeared to be less politically polarised, in the national sense, than they would appear on first examination.

Writing about the pre-war politics of Cheshire, Peter Lake and Richard Cust describe the existence and functioning of a 'middle group' of the Cheshire 'patriot' gentry. This group, led by men of varied religious persuasions (Sir George Booth, Sir Richard Grosvenor, and Sir Richard Wilbraham), was situated between the 'radical proponents of further reform' and the 'conservative defenders of the ecclesiastical status quo'. Its members desperately sought to promote accommodations between parliament and the crown, but the group collapsed when war broke out.²²⁵ Knightley, who later developed connections through the Providence Island Company with the parliamentary faction that had once been determined to appease the crown, was outraged and upset by Buckingham having turned on him in 1625, but still exercised his duties as JP until his death. He might be regarded as belonging to a similar group of patriotic Puritans during the Personal Rule. This is not to say that Knightley was ever aligned with the government. In the parliaments of the 1620s, Knightley thundered against a range of enemies one would expect a Puritan of his standing to oppose: papists, the Spanish, and the Duke of Buckingham, who he came to believe had orchestrated his removal from parliament in 1625. One should not, however, try to model Knightley's politics only by reference to his most aggressive parliamentary speeches. As Sir Benjamin Rudyerd, the Puritan moderate and close associate of Knightley through the Providence Island Company, complained of the tenor of parliament in 1624 (something to which he certainly contributed from time to time), 'we may

²²⁴Patrick Collinson, *De Republica Anglorum, or, History with the Politics Put Back* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1990), 23.

²²⁵Richard Cust and Peter Lake, *Gentry Culture and the Politics of Religion: Cheshire on the Eve of Civil War* (Manchester: Manchester University Press, 2020), 252.

blowe up this house without gunpowder; we may do it with our own passions'.²²⁶

Knightley, like so many across the country, was aggravated to the point of action by the imposition of unparliamentary taxes during the Personal Rule, from the Forced Loan to Ship Money. These far overstepped the boundaries of ordinary taxation, and the weak defence mounted for them - for example, Charles's insistence that Ship Money was necessary for coastal defences against pirates and Turks - cannot have made men like Knightley any more willing to support unquestioned payment of the charge.²²⁷ However, alongside protesting their unparliamentary nature, Knightley paid these charges and continued to fulfil his enforcement duties as a local officer. Moreover, the only evidence that Knightley's interventions constituted efforts to undermine the actual collection of taxes comes from his county enemies. Like many other Puritans of his time, Knightley appears to have felt threatened by the increasing attacks on the reformed faith under Laud. Through his patronage of priests and administration of his own chapel, he opposed the ceremonialist novelties of the Laudian movement. However, without Laud's heavy-handed campaign for the 'beauty of holiness', Knightley might not have sat too far outside the Puritan mainstream. Indeed, one of the ministers whom Knightley has been branded an extremist for supporting had previously ministered to Charles I. Puritanism encompassed a surprisingly broad spectrum of beliefs about politics and church government, and before the 1640s, the distinctions between different strands of Puritanism were often more subtle than contemporaries and later scholars have recognised. Considering this and given the more diverse web of associations that Knightley enjoyed, it does not seem appropriate to categorise him simply as a radical Puritan.

²²⁶ *Memoirs of Sir Benjamin Rudyerd*, ed. J. A. Manning (London: 1841), 62, 116.

²²⁷ John Morrill, *The Revolt of the Provinces: Conservatives and Radicals in the English Civil War, 1630-1650* (London: Allen and Unwin, 1976), 24-31.

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